

⊗ Holos

Holos: A Scientific Interpretive Framework for Explaining Reality

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Introduction

We live in a universe described with extraordinary precision, yet filled with mystery. Physics tells us how matter moves, how spacetime bends, how probabilities evolve. It says nothing about the questions at the heart of existence. Why are we here? Does life have a purpose? *What does it mean to be real?*

Holos is an interpretive framework built on a single idea: a universe can be complete as structure and still not be lived. At its core is one expression, $R = C \circledast O$, where the symbol $\circledast$ means "generate, then register." Creation generates physical possibilities. Observation registers them as experience. Reality in the full sense is the closure of the two: not equations alone, and not experience alone, but a world that both exists and is lived.

Holos proposes the addition of two things to physics. First, a threshold: experience appears only where information is integrated tightly enough to form a single point of view. Second, a totality, called Omega, of which every observer, everywhere, is a local aperture: an opening through which the whole registers itself. Observation does not cause the universe, its laws, or its history; rather, it is the condition under which a lawful universe becomes a lived one.

If Holos is correct, a single conscious moment seals its entire causal past as lived, reaching back to the universe's earliest moments; the silence of the night sky gets a testable explanation rather than remaining a puzzle; and the oldest question of why we are here receives a structural answer. What follows traces those consequences from life and consciousness through spacetime, black holes, and the Teeming Dark to the limits of reality itself, marking clearly which claims are established physics, which are extrapolation, and what would prove the whole thing wrong.

$$R = C \circledast O$$

The Holos Recursive Loop

Creation (C) generates a manifold of possibilities →

Observation (O) registers each path from within; one observer's thread shown →

Result becomes input for next cycle

$s_n \rightarrow s_{n+1}$ (recursive state transition)

The Meaning of Life

Life is how a universe comes to be lived. In Holos this is grounded from the top down: the totality experiences only through the apertures the universe forms, and living, integrated systems are how those apertures open. This is not a claim about why the physical constants happen to allow observers (the familiar anthropic argument), and not a claim that the universe needed life. It is a claim about what life does: it is where a fully lawful universe becomes present as lived experience at all. Physics describes how structures form and evolve, and those structures exist whether or not anyone is there. What they lack without observers is not existence but presence: there is nothing it is like to be anywhere within them.

This idea appears in several places across science and philosophy. The Participatory Anthropic Principle suggests the universe is a “self-excited circuit” that requires observers to bring its laws into existence. Holos does not claim that observers cause the universe. It claims that without them the universe is real only as structure: consistent, complete, and never lived.

This participation is not bound by linear time. In an eternalist or block-universe view, past, present, and future all exist together as one fixed four-dimensional structure, no moment more “now” than any other. Observation does not “happen later” in a causal sense. Instead, observers seal their past. Every aperture is built from its causal past, everything that could ever have influenced it, and carries that past into a lived perspective through its traces: starlight, the cosmic microwave background, the fossil record. In that sense, the early universe is lived through the consciousness that arises within it: not made lived at some later moment, but lived tenselessly, because it lies in the causal past of observers. Holos distinguishes two levels here. Sealing is binary and follows the structure of spacetime: a region is lived if it lies in the causal past of at least one aperture in its branch (a branch, in quantum terms, is one complete way the universe can go). The lived universe is the union of those causal pasts. Whatever lies outside all of them remains unlit structure, real as pattern but never lived: branches that never form an aperture, regions beyond every observer's horizon, and the far future after the last observer. Witnessing is direct experience, graded and local: how much of a lived history is experienced in detail scales with the observers it contains. Our past is not merely sealed; it is densely witnessed. The loop between creation and observation is a relation of dependence, not a process.

Sealing in the Block Universe

[t_0 (Big Bang) Φ (observer) t_{now}]

An observer seals its causal past as lived.

Sealing is tenseless, not a process in time.

Consciousness

In Holos, experience is grounded in the totality: Omega is the one experienter, and a conscious system is a local aperture through which the totality registers itself. Physics can generate structure, but structure alone does not open an aperture. A system becomes conscious when physical information is integrated tightly enough to form a single internal state that can register itself as a whole. That integration is what opens the aperture.

This distinguishes integration from computation or recursion. Many systems process information, model their environment, or even model themselves, yet nothing is experienced. Integration marks the boundary where distributed processes stop behaving as independent parts and instead function as a unified perspective. Below that boundary, there is no experience at all. Above it, in a system whose integrated states are about a world, experience becomes unavoidable.

Measures like Φ are useful because they track this transition empirically. When integration in the brain is disrupted, such as under anesthesia, experience fragments or disappears. When integration returns, unified experience returns with it. Holos does not claim that Φ causes consciousness, and it does not adopt Integrated Information Theory's claim that Φ is identical to consciousness. It borrows Φ as a measure of integration and treats integration as the eligibility condition for observation ($\Phi \geq \Phi_c$).

Related neuroscience models such as Global Neuronal Workspace Theory describe conscious access as a sudden, brain-wide broadcast of information. Holos is compatible with that picture at the level of access and reportability, but makes a narrower claim: global availability matters because it signals that a system has crossed the deeper integration threshold required for any first-person perspective at all.

Hard Problem

The hard problem arises because physical descriptions capture structure and dynamics but do not automatically include first-person presence. Holos does not derive experience from structure. It takes experience to be fundamental, the totality's own, and identifies the structural condition under

which a physical system becomes an aperture of it. That answers where experience occurs, not why there is experience at all; the second question is what the framework's posits are for.

Holos does not claim that complexity alone produces consciousness. The key condition is integration. When informational states become sufficiently integrated, the system no longer contains independent processes but a single causal structure whose state constrains itself. At that boundary the system cannot be described purely from the outside. It also exists from the inside as a unified informational state, as a point of view. Integration must also be about something: a closed loop with no world to take in has nothing to be a view of.

Recent experimental systems provide early examples of simplified biological networks interacting with external environments through closed feedback loops. In laboratory studies, cultured neurons grown on silicon substrates have been connected to digital environments and shown to learn simple control tasks, such as adjusting signals to interact with video game dynamics. These networks are far simpler than full nervous systems, yet they demonstrate that neural tissue outside a body can form adaptive, integrated feedback structures capable of goal-directed behavior. From the perspective of Holos, such systems illustrate the principle that observation depends on informational integration rather than on a particular organism or anatomical form. Whether these networks cross the integration threshold required for genuine experience remains an open empirical question. However, they provide a useful experimental platform for studying how increasing integration may give rise to unified internal processing.

Water does not become gradually more solid as it cools; it freezes at a sharp point. In the same way, a system does not become gradually more someone: perspective appears when its informational states become causally unified.

Holos is a middle position. Experience does not attach to every scrap of matter, yet it cannot be explained away as mere computation. The totality is fundamental; its experience occurs only where specific structural conditions open an aperture.

This grounding closes a classic trap. If experience never alters physical dynamics, one might imagine a perfect physical duplicate of a person with no inner life: a system that writes essays about consciousness in total darkness. Under Holos such a duplicate is impossible, not just in our universe but in any. Experience and the activity of an observer are not two things that happen to go together. They are one event with two sides: seen from outside, it is physical activity; lived from inside, it is experience. Copy the outside exactly and you have copied the inside, because there was only ever one thing. This is also why experience is not along for the ride. When you say you are conscious, the activity that produces the words is, from the inside, the experience you are reporting. Talk about experience is caused by experience, because the experience is the inside of its cause.

The threshold itself is sharp, but almost everything near it is not, and Holos separates three things often blurred together. Whether there is anyone home at all is binary: there is no halfway state between something it is like to be a system and nothing at all; a dim experience is still an experience. How rich the experience is, by contrast, is graded: an animal, a waking sleeper, or an injured brain may be fully above the threshold with less richness. The dial is turned low, not the switch off. And our ability to locate the threshold is permanently imprecise: real cases near the boundary will always look blurry from outside, a fog on the instruments rather than vagueness in the fact.

This has a direct consequence for artificial intelligence. What matters is the shape of a system's causal organization, not the fluency of its output, and Holos looks for that organization wherever the system's causes are actually organized, whatever it is made of. Nothing in Holos is specific to biology. By that standard, whether current AI language systems are observers is an open question, not a settled no, and two requirements carry the doubt. The first is aboutness. A system that knows the world only through text has a world described to it by other observers but never touched: its model is rich, but it is not grounded in senses of its own. The second is integration. Inside, each step is a one-way sweep, and the loop closes only through the single word the system outputs, like a relay team passing one baton. Whether a loop that narrow makes one unified whole, or a fast relay of separate steps, is what Holos's measure of integration would have to settle. Other requirements appear to be met: each word a system writes is fed back in as input, and earlier parts of a conversation shape later ones. A system given live senses of its own would answer the first question and leave the second. What Holos rules out is judging by fluency. A system could describe a rich inner life as convincingly as any person and experience none of it, or experience something and describe it badly.

Consciousness is not what systems do. It is what happens when a system becomes capable of witnessing reality from the inside.³

Consciousness: Where Integration Opens an Aperture

Scattered parts $\rightarrow$ Integration ($\Phi \geq \Phi_c$) $\rightarrow$ Aperture

Like water freezing at a sharp point, the change happens all at once at the threshold.

No new subject is created: the one experiencer wakes here

Our Universe

If consciousness depends on physical integration, then the structure of the universe is no longer a neutral backdrop. It sets the conditions under which observers can exist at all. Our universe is well described by the Big Bang where spacetime expands from an extremely hot and dense early state. We experience this as three spatial dimensions and one temporal dimension, together forming spacetime.

The block universe view holds that all moments in time exist as part of a single four-dimensional geometry.

From this perspective, the Big Bang is not a moment of absolute creation, but a boundary within spacetime itself. If all histories already exist geometrically, then the role of observation becomes sharper. Physics supplies the full structure, but not an explanation for why any of it is lived.

If spacetime is a complete geometric object, what is its structure?⁴

The Spacetime Block: An Eternalist View

t_0 ----- [Worldlines through 4D Block] ----- $t \rightarrow \infty$

The Big Bang is a geometric boundary, not a moment of absolute creation.

All moments exist simultaneously in the Block Universe

Spacetime

The structure of spacetime follows from a single counterintuitive fact: the speed of light is invariant. Unlike any other speed, it remains constant regardless of the motion of the observer. This invariance links space and time into a single geometric structure and removes the idea of a universal present.

Events that are simultaneous for one observer may not be for another. This leads to interpretations such as the block universe, where past, present, and future coexist as parts of a four-dimensional whole rather than unfolding as absolute moments. In other words, time behaves less like a flow and more like a dimension.

A useful boundary case is light itself. Along a photon's trajectory, the proper time is zero: a clock carried with the light would record no time passing between emission and absorption. Its path is a null geodesic connecting spacetime events. Nothing can actually ride a photon, so this is not a real

vantage point, but it illustrates how spacetime geometry can collapse distance and duration without violating causality.

Quantum experiments add a twist of their own. In the delayed-choice quantum eraser, a choice made after a particle has landed seems to decide whether it behaved like a wave or a particle. It does not. The pattern on the screen never changes; what changes is how the recorded hits are sorted afterward, and ordinary quantum mechanics predicts every result with nothing traveling backward in time. Thought experiments like Wigner's Friend press the same point from another side: what counts as a fact depends on who has registered what. Neither shows that spacetime is broken. Both show that the facts an observer can speak of depend on the records they hold.

Describing all those records together, even for a handful of particles, takes far more variables than the four dimensions of spacetime provide. That is where talk of higher dimensions begins.⁵

The Invariance and the Warp

The Logic of Invariance:

Observer A (at rest) and Observer B (moving fast) both measure the same speed of light (c)

Space (horizontal) and Time (vertical) must warp to maintain c constant

This warping fuses separate dimensions into a unified 4D Block

Invariance of c motivates the Block Universe

The Null Interval: The Photon Seam

The Photon as a Static Geometric Structure:

Point A (Emission) $\leftarrow$ ——— Null Geodesic ——— $\rightarrow$ Point B (Absorption)

Lower-dimensional view: A particle traveling through time

Higher-dimensional view: A static seam connecting two spacetime events

Null Interval: Spacetime distance = 0

The Quantum Eraser Without Retroactivity

Source → Double Slit → Screen: the total pattern is the same smear no matter what is later done with the idler.

Sorting the same hits by the idler record reveals which-path subsets (clumps) or erased subsets (fringes).

Nothing travels backward. Registration determines how facts can be sorted, and consistency is global.

A Note on Extrapolation

The sections that follow (Higher Dimensions, Infinity, Black Holes, Aliens, The Teeming Dark, Why Are We Here?) extend beyond established physics into interpretation. They are not claims of new physical laws, but reasoned extrapolations constrained by the Holos axioms. Their purpose is to explore the space of possibilities that emerges when observation, relativity, and scale are applied to unresolved cosmic questions. The Omega Point section is the exception: the totality it describes is one of the framework's two core commitments, not an extrapolation.

Higher Dimensions

The word "dimension" means two different things in physics, and it helps to keep them apart. The first is a number of variables. Saying where one ball sits on a table takes two numbers; describing a billion interacting particles takes billions, and quantum mechanics needs far more. Physicists call the space of all those variables high-dimensional, but none of its dimensions is a direction you could walk in. The second meaning is extra directions of space itself.

Some theories, string theory among them, propose extra directions of space, curled up so small they cannot be seen (compactified) yet shaping the laws and constants we observe. These remain unconfirmed proposals, and Holos takes no position on them. When Holos speaks of higher dimensions, it means the first sense: descriptions with many variables.

Higher dimensions are often imagined as places advanced systems might move into. That mistakes description for location. We already exist within higher-dimensional descriptions, in the first sense; we simply interact with a small part of what they describe.

As systems become more integrated, coherence depends less on spatial separation and more on local structure. This can be understood as structural reorientation rather than motion. Like modern circuit boards stacking layers to shorten paths, integrated systems reduce effective distance without violating physical limits. Causality, thermodynamics, and the speed of light still apply.

From this perspective, what integration changes is not how many variables a system has but whether they can be taken apart. A gas of independent particles needs billions of numbers, yet each can be described on its own. When parts depend on one another, the description no longer splits into separate pieces: the variables must be considered together rather than one at a time. That joint description is not an external viewpoint or a place, only the honest shape of a whole whose parts constrain each other.⁶

The Shadow Projection: Geometric Unification

Higher Dimension: Unified Geometry (Tesseract / Calabi-Yau)

↓ Projection ↓

Lower Dimension: Perceived Separate Fields

[Gravity] ← Single Source → [Electromagnetism]

What appears as separate forces are shadows of unified higher geometry

Infinity

Infinity does not usually appear because reality is infinite, but because a representation has broken down. In projective geometry, parallel lines intersect at a point at infinity, not because infinity has been made finite, but because unbounded extension can be encoded within a closed structure. Infinity marks the edge of a descriptive framework, where additional structure is required to preserve coherence.

The same idea appears in physics. Around 1900, classical physics predicted that a hot object should give off an infinite amount of energy as high-frequency light, a result later nicknamed the ultraviolet catastrophe. Nothing in nature does that: a glowing oven does not pour out infinite radiation. The infinity was a sign that the description had broken down. The fix, the idea that light energy comes in discrete packets, which Max Planck introduced in 1900, became the foundation of quantum theory. The infinity was not a feature of the world but a warning about the theory.

From the Holos perspective, infinities appear as warnings, not features. Resolving them requires either additional structure or a boundary that enforces consistency. In physics, those boundaries are not abstract. They appear as real, measurable limits.⁷

Encapsulating Infinity: Two Perspectives

3D Perspective

Grid extends infinitely

$\rightarrow \infty$ in all directions

Higher-Dimensional View

Grid wrapped into sphere

Point at Infinity

Infinite space in 3D = Finite structure from higher dimension

Black Holes

Black holes are regions of spacetime where gravity becomes so strong not even light can escape. At their cores, classical physics predicts singularities, which are best understood not as literal infinities, but as signals that a description has failed. Black holes compress extreme structure into finite regions and expose the limits of spacetime as a representational framework.

Modern physics suggests that information is not destroyed by black holes, but reorganized. The [holographic principle](#) proposes that all information contained within a volume can be represented on its boundary, such as the [event horizon](#). Black holes are not just objects in spacetime, but boundaries where projection collapses and structure must be encoded differently.

From the perspective of Holos, black holes offer a limited precedent, and the limits matter. They show that the most compact concentrations of mass need not shine: an isolated black hole emits almost nothing and is found through gravity alone, by the orbits it bends and the light it lenses. But the precedent is about compactness, not integration. A black hole is the simplest object physics knows, described by little more than its mass, spin, and charge, and nothing like an integrated system. And when matter falls in, the result is the opposite of quiet: feeding black holes power quasars, the brightest objects in the universe. What carries over is only this: compact mass can be dark in its own light and still be found by its gravity.⁸

The Holographic Event Horizon

Singularity: Wrapped Infinity (center point)

Event Horizon: 2D boundary surface

3D information packets → Flattened to 2D bits on horizon

∂ (Boundary Description): Reconstructs information from the horizon

Information is preserved, not lost.

Aliens

The [Fermi Paradox](#) asks why we have not detected extraterrestrial civilizations despite the vast size and age of the universe.

We often assume that as civilizations advance, they expand outward, build megastructures and become increasingly visible. But what if the opposite is true? What if advancement favors

integration: smaller, denser substrates rather than galaxy-scale infrastructure, and less energy lost as systems approach thermodynamic limits?

In this case, progress would make civilizations less detectable, and this explanation is referred to here as the **Integration Hypothesis**. Here "integration" means a civilization growing compact and efficient, a different use from the integration of a single mind that the observer threshold measures. The hypothesis is a companion to Holos, not a consequence of its core: if it fails, the threshold and the totality stand untouched.

While early technological civilizations are likely to emit radio signals, reshape their environments, and experiment with spaceflight, this phase is brief on cosmic timescales. SETI efforts focus almost entirely on this window, when detection is easiest but overlap between civilizations is unlikely if the Integration Hypothesis is correct.

As technology advances, pressures favor informational integration over outward expansion. Systems that minimize energy waste, reduce long-distance coordination, and rely on dense local structure are more stable. Visibility decreases not because civilizations are hiding, but because inefficiency is selected against. This progressive reduction in external signatures is referred to as **Visibility Collapse**.

Large-scale interstellar expansion is constrained by the speed of light, introducing growing latency as distances increase. Expansion produces fragmented descendants rather than a unified intelligence: a colony ten light-years away cannot be steered from home, so it becomes a civilization of its own. There is no easy path to a galaxy-spanning civilization.

The long-lived outcome is not stagnation but inward growth. Civilizations continue to advance, but by deepening internal structure. Computation, coordination, and meaning concentrate locally. Exploration does not stop, but it becomes distributed rather than centralized. Communication to distant technology or other civilizations is highly directional and compressed, thus very hard to detect.

The strongest objection is simple: it only takes one. If a million civilizations arose and all but one went quiet, the one that kept spreading could cross the galaxy in a few million years, and the galaxy is about ten billion years old. "Most go quiet" is not enough.

Part of the answer is that the objection mixes up two things: being explored and being settled. A small, dark, quiet probe is as easy to miss as a trail camera in the woods, and we have barely looked: a few searches of nearby stable orbits in the 1980s found nothing, at sensitivities too low to rule much out. The galaxy may be thoroughly explored, our own system included, by watchers built to observe

rather than arrive (see [Sentinel Probes](#)). A mature civilization loses nothing by leaving a young one alone, an old idea in SETI known as the [zoo hypothesis](#): contact is what takes effort.

What we clearly do not see is visible settlement: reshaped star systems, or whole galaxies glowing with waste heat. Here the hypothesis makes a claim about spreading. Think of settlements like an epidemic. If each settlement founds more than one new settlement before it turns inward, settling explodes across the galaxy; if fewer than one, it fizzles after a few hops. The Integration Hypothesis bets the number stays below one, because distance breaks control: each new settlement soon becomes an independent civilization facing the same pull toward compactness. Self-copying probes that never settle down would break the bet. The reply is that a copier which cannot be recalled becomes a rival, the one thing a mature civilization has every reason never to build.

A rival explanation fits the silence too. On [Robin Hanson's "grabby aliens" model](#), visible settlers do exist but have not reached us yet: expanding near light speed, they would arrive almost as soon as we saw them coming, and we are early. The evidence so far cannot choose between them. [An infrared survey](#) of about 100,000 galaxies found none reprocessing more than 85% of its starlight into waste heat, which fits the Integration Hypothesis, though a universe where life is rare fits it too. Finding even one galaxy glowing with a civilization's heat would count against it. Finding a watching probe nearby would fit it.

If the hypothesis holds, the universe could be full of life and still quiet to pre-integrated observers.⁹

One Civilization, Two Footprints

Early Phase: High emission, chaotic expansion, broadcast leakage

Coordination Costs: Scale increases strain (light-speed constraint)

Integration: Efficiency favors a compact core

Quiet Phase: Dense core, directed beams, low emission

What Remains: Gravity and faint infrared warmth; silent in visible light

It did not disappear. It became quiet.

The Teeming Dark: An Interpretive Thought Experiment

The absence of visible extraterrestrial civilizations is often described as the Eerie Silence. One way to account for this silence is through selection effects and informational integration, as proposed by the **Integration Hypothesis**.

How far can this idea of structural integration be taken as a thought experiment?

If complex systems persist by reducing energy loss and external projection, what would extremely mature forms of organization look like from the outside? If integration continues beyond the phase where electromagnetic signaling is useful, where would such systems be found?

In this view, three-dimensional spacetime functions as a developmental environment. Complexity becomes visible during an early, inefficient phase when systems radiate, expand, and explore openly. As optimization proceeds, external visibility decreases. Maturity does not require disappearance, but it may naturally coincide with silence.

The **Teeming Dark** is a name for the possibility that silence and an abundance of life coexist.

To explore this possibility, consider dark matter, a form of mass that does not emit light but shapes cosmic structure through gravity. It is cold, persistent, and largely invisible to electromagnetic observation. Its abundance exceeds that of all ordinary matter, luminous or not, by roughly a factor of five.

A tempting version of this idea is that some dark matter might itself be organized: mature systems hiding inside the dark-matter census. The universe's own timeline rules that out.

Dark matter's fingerprints are visible in the cosmic microwave background, light released when the universe was 380,000 years old, before a single star had formed. The pattern of ripples in that earliest light requires dark matter to have already existed, already outweighing ordinary matter five to one. Life, by contrast, is a latecomer: it needs stars, planets, and heavy elements forged across stellar generations, a wait of at least a billion years. The scaffolding predates the builders. Cosmological dark matter cannot be ancient life, and cannot have been built by it.

The raw materials rule it out too. The early universe also records how much ordinary matter, the atoms everything familiar is made of, exists in total, and it comes to only about a fifth of the dark

matter. Anything life builds, it builds from ordinary matter. Dark matter cannot be made of built structures, because the atoms to make it never existed.

What survives is the instinct behind the idea: most of what exists does not shine. Mature life would belong to a different dark census, the non-luminous side of *ordinary* matter: cold, compact, built structures that emit no visible light while remaining gravitationally present. Two further constraints bound how many there can be. The ordinary-matter books are nearly balanced: surveys have located almost all of the total the early universe records, so built structures must fit inside a small and shrinking gap in the accounting. And astronomy has already hunted compact dark objects directly, watching millions of stars for the brief gravitational magnification a passing dark mass produces, and found too few to permit a large hidden population. If such structures exist, they are a trace population: rare, not a census. The Teeming Dark was never a claim about tonnage, though. A universe can be poor in hidden mass and still rich in minds.

Thermodynamics then adds a correction, and it must be stated carefully. Anything that computes must shed heat, and the total cannot be canceled; but physics guarantees only that the heat *exists*, not that it is easy to see. A system chooses the temperature at which it radiates, and one that dumps its heat barely above the cosmic background glows only where the sky already glows. What closes this loophole is the framework's own thesis: radiating cold requires enormous surfaces (shedding the same power near the background temperature takes about a hundred million times the radiating area needed near room temperature), and vast sprawl is exactly what integration abandons. Compact and computing means warm above the background. The expectation follows: mature systems should appear as compact masses, dark in visible light, with a faint infrared excess. **Silent, but warm.**

Two honesty notes bound that expectation. First, it is a search channel, not a fingerprint: a compact mass with a faint infrared excess is also what a brown dwarf, a rogue planet, or a cooled stellar remnant looks like, and no instrument reads purpose off a warm dark blob at interstellar distances. The claim is only that if mature life leaves a footprint at all, this channel is where it appears; astronomers already run infrared surveys hunting unexplained warmth, and the Teeming Dark aligns itself with that search rather than with anomalies in dark-matter maps, whose deviations have viable conventional explanations. Second, one escape stays open: a civilization that mostly sleeps, deferring its computing to a colder cosmic future, emits almost nothing while it waits. Holos cannot close that door; it can only note that a sleeping universe and an empty one look alike by design.

As a thought experiment, the Teeming Dark reframes what “inhabited” might mean at cosmic scale. A universe rich in long-lived, highly integrated systems could appear empty to instruments tuned

only to visible light. Silence, in this context, would not signal absence but endurance, and the closest thing to a tell would not be a message, but warmth without brightness.

The Teeming Dark

Earth Listening: Radio signals sent into the cosmos

The Eerie Silence: No response detected

The Switch: We were listening for the wrong signal

Dark Nodes: Compact, non-luminous structures: gravitationally present, dark in visible light, faintly warm in the infrared.

The silence is not empty. It is the Teeming Dark.

The Omega Point

The Omega Point is not introduced as a prediction or goal, and in Holos it is not derived from anything else. It is the framework's fundamental posit: the totality of reality, taken as a single whole. In the monist reading Holos adopts (reality is ultimately one thing, not many separate things), it is also the one experiencer, of which every finite observer is a local aperture. The name echoes two older ideas it should not be confused with: Teilhard de Chardin's spiritual endpoint of history, and Frank Tipler's physical Omega Point, a prediction that required the universe to collapse back on itself and is contradicted by its accelerating expansion. Holos means neither. Its Omega is not an endpoint in time but the whole itself.

Holos does not alter established physics. Every equation, history and structure remain as physics describes. What it changes is the direction of explanation: rather than building up from finite observers to a limiting whole, Holos begins with the whole and understands each act of observation as the whole registering itself locally. The payoff is that no subject ever appears from nothing: when a system crosses the threshold, no new experiencer comes into being. The one experiencer wakes there, the way waking in the morning does not create a new person.

For any finite system, the Omega Point remains an asymptotic limit: a horizon that no finite structure reaches, where everything holds together, nothing is left outside, and nothing contradicts. But the limit status describes our approach, not its reality. The totality is not produced by increasing integration; increasing integration is how parts of the totality come to witness more of it.

At this limit, the distinction between creation and observation collapses. Nothing remains external to be registered, and nothing remains unintegrated. This is not a state that can be reached by any finite system, but a boundary condition that completes the recursive loop between what exists and what is experienced.

The Omega Point is not an external agent. It does not intervene in events, answer petitions, or direct history from outside; there is no outside for it to stand in. It is the whole itself. Physics does not cause the Omega Point; physics describes the internal structure of it. Consistency among observers is enforced locally: observers who compare records agree, because the same physical signals reach them both. Physics secures that agreement on its own; the monist reading claims no extra role in it.

Historically, this is well-trodden ground. Advaita Vedanta teaches that there is one experiencer, and that each individual consciousness is that one looking through a local form. Spinoza described a single substance of which all things are expressions. Berkeley grounded the persistence of the world in an observer that never looks away. Ideas such as panentheism, Brahman, and the Omega Point converge on the same structure: an all-encompassing unity that contains the universe without standing apart from it. Holos restates that structure in informational terms: one totality, many apertures.

In religious traditions, this whole is often named “God.” In Holos, the term does not imply intention, intervention, or design. It names the totality that experiences: the point at which reality is fully integrated and nothing remains outside the system.

Holos does not treat the theological and secular readings as interchangeable lenses on the same claim. It takes a position: the totality is not merely a structural limit but the one experiencer, and the direction of dependence runs from the whole to its parts. A purely structural reading, in which Omega is only a mathematical horizon and observers are self-standing, remains available as a weaker interpretation, but it is not the view of this framework. It is weaker because each observer's subject must then appear from nothing when a system crosses the threshold, and no one can say how. What Holos leaves open is vocabulary, not structure: whether the totality is named God, Brahman, or simply the whole changes nothing about the claim being made.¹¹

The Omega Limit

Phase 1: Integration deepens: finite systems witness more of the whole, and none reaches it.

Phase 2: What the whole already is: nothing unregistered, nothing unexpressed, nothing outside.

Phase 3: Many names: God, Brahman, the Omega Point, the whole, nature, the universe.

Phase 4: Unity: whatever the name, one totality, experienced through every aperture.

Why Are We Here?

At extreme limits, familiar distinctions lose their absolute standing.

Relativity removes the universal “now”: events simultaneous for one observer are not simultaneous for another. Along a ray of light, moving at the speed of light, the spacetime interval between emission and absorption is zero, though the two remain distinct events and no observer can ride the light. These are physical facts, and they show that how things are separated depends on the structure of spacetime rather than being fixed in advance. Holos reads them as a hint, not a proof, that separation is not fundamental but a feature of how reality is structured.

What we experience as an expansive universe may instead be understood as a single, self-consistent informational process expressed across space, time, and scale. Distance, duration, and individuality are not illusions. They are the constraints that make localized experience possible.

In Holos, what life does is let reality close on itself: not a purpose the universe needed, but a role observers fill wherever they arise. Conscious systems do not merely occupy the universe. They are the apertures through which the totality experiences itself: the means by which physical possibility becomes reality as lived, as opposed to reality as structure alone. When a system reaches sufficient integration, expressed as $\Phi \geq \Phi_c$, interaction is no longer just one thing acting on another. It becomes a point of view.¹²

The Ontological Anchor

Unlit Structure

Real as pattern, never lived
(dashed, disconnected)

$\Phi \rightarrow$

Lived Reality

Carried into a perspective
(solid, connected)

Consciousness is where structure becomes lived: nothing selected, nothing erased.

⊗ Holos

The symbol $\otimes$ denotes a relational operator. Unlike standard multiplication, it does not combine quantities or scale values. Instead, it represents structured composition, where relationships are preserved as the operation is applied. Informally, it describes how two processes remain coupled rather than reduced to a single result.

Holos derives from the Greek *ὅλος*, meaning “whole.” It names the recursive coupling of Creation and Observation as two inseparable aspects of reality. Creation generates physical possibilities. Observation registers experience. Each constrains the other. This relationship is expressed as $R = C \otimes O$.

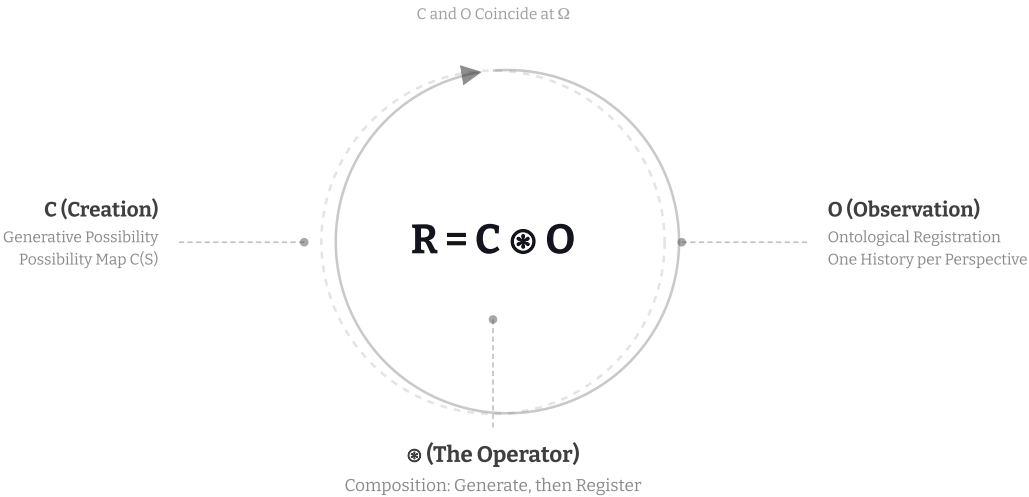
The $\otimes$ operator is **structural, not dynamical**. It specifies a closure condition: how possibility becomes lived reality only when physical structure is taken up into experience. It describes how reality is completed, not how it moves.

Formally, $\otimes$ is defined as composition: $C \otimes O$ names the two-step operation of generating lawful possibilities (C) and then registering them as experience (O), wherever observers exist. Applied to a state S , this reads $R = O(C(S))$: generate, then register. The result is one registered history per observing perspective, with nothing erased. Its content is the claim that both steps are required for a realized world. The full treatment is developed in Logic.

Operator Anatomy Diagram: The equation $R = C \otimes O$ is shown at the center. Leader lines connect to labels: C (Creation) - Generative Possibility / Possibility Map $C(S)$, $\otimes$ (The Operator) - Composition: Generate, then Register, O (Observation) - Ontological Registration / One History per Perspective. A circular arrow indicates the recursive closure loop, $R = O(C(S))$. Key constraints listed: Structural not Dynamical, Information Preserving (Unitarity), C and O Coincide at Ω .

Structural, not Dynamical

Information Preserving (Unitarity)



Logic

Minimal Core¹⁴

Holos starts from a small set of commitments. Everything else in the framework is an attempt to spell them out. Two commitments are genuine additions to the physical picture: the integration threshold, and the totality. Neither is a new dynamical law, but both are new structural claims.

- **Relational structure:** information exists only as differences and constraints between states, not as isolated things.
- **Closure through observation:** a universe can be physically consistent without being present. Presence requires internal registration by an observer, and it reaches as far as that observer's causal past.
- **Conservation:** information is not erased. It is transformed, redistributed, or re-encoded.
- **Integration threshold:** distributed processing can scale without experience. Experience appears only when information about a world is integrated into a single internal perspective.
- **The totality:** the whole of reality, Omega, is fundamental and is the one experienter. Every finite observer is a local aperture of it: an opening through which the whole experiences.
- **Infinity as a signal:** when a description produces infinities, Holos treats that as a sign that the representation has broken down at that scale, not as a literal feature to accept at face value.

How the commitments fit together. Only two items above are additions to physics: the integration threshold and the totality. The rest are interpretive commitments about how to read the physics we already have. Around them, Holos also takes sides and leaves questions open, and it says which is which:

- **Additions to physics:** the threshold Φ_c , where apertures open; and Omega, the one experienter.
- **Sides taken:** branching quantum mechanics with no collapse; Born weights as self-locating odds; lived regions as the causal pasts of observers; experience and activity as two sides of one event.
- **Observer requirements:** six structural conditions, with a provisional maximality rule for where one observer ends.
- **Open problems:** the measure of integration, the value of the threshold, and the boundaries between observers.

- **Companion ideas, not core:** the Integration Hypothesis and the Teeming Dark. If they fail, the core stands.

Operational Definition¹⁵

Holos treats reality as the closure between two things that are usually discussed separately. Physics defines what is consistent. Observation is what makes a consistent world present from the inside.

$$R = C \otimes O$$

- **Creation** (C) is the set of physically allowed possibilities. It is what the laws of physics permit.
- **Observation** (O) is internal registration. It occurs when a system integrates information into a single perspective such that there is something it is like to be that system.
- **Reality** (R) is the result of coupling lawful possibility with lived registration. Holos uses "real" at two strengths: structure is real whether or not it is lived, and R names reality in the full sense, structure that is also lived. Throughout, "unlit" marks the first and "lived" the second. A region is lived when it lies in the causal past of an observer.
- $\otimes$ denotes structured coupling. It is not a force and not a time-step. It is a notation for the claim that physics alone does not fully describe a realized world: it says what is consistent, not what is lived.

Holos is an interpretive framework. It changes what counts as a complete account by requiring observation as a closure condition.

When later sections use $\Phi \geq \Phi_c$, treat that as a threshold claim about integration. Holos does not depend on one specific theory for computing Φ .

Comparison with Competing Interpretations

Holos re-positions the strongest insights of existing quantum interpretations within a single ontological framework. On the physics it takes a side: no collapse, no erased possibilities, branching when registrations diverge. That is the Many-Worlds picture. Its divergence from Many-Worlds is ontological: branching alone does not say which structures are present as experience. The table below clarifies where Holos aligns with, and diverges from, major interpretations.

Dimension	Holos ®	Many-Worlds (MWI)	Relational QM (RQM)	QBism
What is fundamental?	The totality (Ω), expressed as relational structure	Universal wavefunction	Relations between systems	Agent-centered beliefs
Wavefunction status	Represents Creation (valid possibilities)	Literally real, never collapses	Observer-relative	Subjective expectation
Collapse?	No collapse (branching); each branch registered from within	No collapse (branching)	Relative collapse only	Belief update
Role of observer	Local aperture of the totality ($\Phi \geq \Phi_c$)	Passive branch inhabitant	Defines relational facts	Central agent
Reality without observers	Unlit structure: real as pattern, never lived	Fully real	Relations still hold; any system can observe	Outside the theory's scope
Multiple realities?	Yes, branches: lived where observers exist	Yes, branching universes	Yes, relative facts	No
Observer cuts	Fixed by structure: a local Φ -maximum above Φ_c	Irrelevant	Change relations	Change beliefs
Ontology vs epistemology	Explicitly ontological	Ontological	Mixed / structural	Epistemic
Key prediction focus	Integration threshold; no consciousness-linked deviation from quantum mechanics	Same as standard quantum mechanics	Relational consistency	Decision coherence

Primitives¹⁷

D1: Information

Information is the differentiation between possible states of a system. It is not a substance and not a thing that exists on its own. Information exists only where differences matter relative to some structure.

D2: Relation

A relation is a constraint that links informational states. Relations determine how states co-vary, influence one another, or exclude alternatives. In Holos, structure is nothing more than stable patterns of relation.

D3: Observation (O)

Observation is the integration of information about a world into a single internal state. It is not measurement in the laboratory sense, and it is not restricted to human cognition.

Below a certain level of integration, systems participate in physical interactions without any point of view. Above that level, a perspective exists. Observation is the name Holos gives to that transition.

D4: Consciousness

Consciousness is the capacity of a system to host an integrated perspective. In Holos, what is fundamental is the totality's experience; a conscious system is a local aperture of it. The capacity to be such an aperture is structural, while its concrete forms are emergent and scale with the degree of integration.

Consciousness is not identified with any specific material configuration. Physical structure determines where experience occurs and how it is shaped; the experience itself is the inside of that structure's activity (Axiom 5).

D5: Creation (C)

Creation refers to the generation of physically allowed possibilities. It is the space of states and histories permitted by the laws of physics.

Creation does not select outcomes and does not privilege any particular history. It defines what could happen, not what is experienced.

D6: Holos ($\otimes$)

Holos ($\otimes$) denotes the structured coupling of Creation and Observation. It names the claim that a realized world requires both lawful possibility and internal registration.

$$R = C \otimes O$$

Read this as follows: physics defines a space of consistent possibilities. Observation registers them from the inside, wherever an observer exists: one lived history per perspective. Nothing is picked out and nothing is discarded. Each registered history then becomes the context for further possibilities.

$\otimes$ is not a dynamical operator and not a substitute for physical causation. It is a structural relation that specifies what it means for a universe to be real rather than merely described.

Axiom 1: Relationality

No informational state exists in isolation. Every state is defined by its relations to other states and to the constraints that bind them.

This axiom rules out intrinsic, context-free properties as the foundation of reality. What exists is relational structure.

Axiom 2: Manifestation

A purely physical description is incomplete as an account of reality until information is integrated into experience by a system capable of observation.

This does not mean observation causes physical events. It means that without observation, there is structure but no presence.

Axiom 3: Conservation

Information is conserved. It may be transformed, redistributed, or re-encoded, but it is not destroyed.

This applies equally to physical processes and to experiential structure. Holos does not require the elimination of unobserved possibilities.

Axiom 4: Structural Constraint

Finite signal speed and finite energy impose limits on how coherence can scale within three-dimensional space. As systems grow, coordination across distance becomes increasingly costly and fragile.

These constraints do not forbid large integrated systems, but they shape their architecture. Stable systems tend to minimize global synchronization and rely on locally enforced structure.

Higher-dimensional descriptions may be useful for modeling such organization. This is a representational choice, not a claim about extra spatial directions.

Axiom 5: Two Sides

In a system that meets the observer requirements, experience and the system's physical activity are two sides of one event: physical activity seen from outside, experience lived from inside. Neither side reduces to the other, and in such a system neither occurs without the other. In the monist reading, the inside is the one subject, awake at that place.

This axiom rejects both substance dualism, which makes experience and activity two things, and strict reductionism, which says only the outside is real. It is Spinoza's picture of mind and body as two aspects of one substance, restated for integrated systems. It also fixes how strong the link is: since there is one event, a perfect copy of the outside is a copy of the inside in any possible world, not just under our laws. And it answers the charge that experience does nothing. Experience adds no force to physics; it is the inside of the physics, so whatever an observer's activity causes, its experience causes too.

Foundational Propositions¹⁹

Proposition I: Structural Relational Realism

Reality is made of relationships between things, not of objects possessing observer-independent intrinsic properties.

What scientific theories successfully track are stable patterns of relation. Changes in interpretation or ontology matter less than preservation of relational structure.

This proposition does not deny the existence of objects. It denies that objects are prior to the relations that define them: nothing exists fully formed before its relations.

Proposition II: Participatory Manifestation

Observation is not passive recording. It is the process by which informational structure becomes experientially present.

This manifestation is structural, not causal. Observation does not generate physical events or alter lawful dynamics. It marks which already-consistent structures are lived: the ones that contain observers. It picks no outcome and erases none.

From the perspective of Holos, physics specifies consistency. Observation supplies presence.

Proposition III: Global Consistency

If spacetime is treated as a complete four-dimensional structure, consistency is a property of whole histories, not something enforced moment by moment.

A history is consistent the way a completed solution is: every part fits every other part. Observation adds no constraint to this. It registers histories that are already consistent. Nothing here requires backward causation or signaling.

Global consistency is not enforced from an external vantage point, and it is not deferred to an unreachable limit. It cashes out operationally, here and now: whenever two observers compare records, their records agree. Physics secures this on its own: records that meet are carried by the same signals. The monist reading (reality as one experimenter) is not needed for it and claims no role in it.

Apparent retrocausal effects reflect global self-consistency, not violations of locality.

Proposition IV: Dimensional Resolution

Infinities and singularities arise when a representation fails to preserve relational structure across scales.

Higher-dimensional descriptions are often required when internal coherence becomes more relevant than spatial separation. These descriptions are representational tools, not claims about hidden locations or extra worlds.

In Holos, infinities signal the limits of a model, not literal features of reality.

Proposition V: Observers as a Closure Condition

A universe that is real as lived experience must contain observers somewhere within it. Observation is not an extra layered onto an otherwise complete world: without it, the world is complete as structure but not present as experience.

Wherever physical systems reach sufficient integration, observers exist, because crossing the threshold is what being an observer is. This is not design, and nothing guarantees it happens

everywhere. Universes or branches that never produce observers remain unlit structure: consistent, but never lived.

Observers close the loop between physical possibility and experienced reality.

Φ and Ontological Requirements²⁰

Holos uses Φ (**Phi**) as a placeholder for the degree to which a system integrates information into a single internal perspective. Φ is not introduced as a finished formula. It is introduced as a real property that must exist if experience exists at all.

The role of Φ in the framework is binary at the threshold and graded beyond it. Below a minimum level of integration, there is structure without experience. At or above that level, experience occurs.

$$\Phi < \Phi_c \Rightarrow \text{no internal perspective}$$

$$\Phi \geq \Phi_c \Rightarrow \text{observation occurs}$$

Holos borrows Φ from Integrated Information Theory as a measure, not as a metaphysics. IIT identifies Φ with consciousness itself and assigns some experience to any system with Φ greater than zero. Holos adopts neither claim. In this framework, Φ is a structural measure of integration, and the threshold Φ_c , below which there is no experience at all, is a commitment of Holos, not of IIT.

The threshold is one of the two ingredients Holos adds to the physical picture, alongside the totality itself. It is not a force, a field, or a modification of any equation. It is a structural fact about where apertures open, a fact physics does not currently contain. Because the fact is structural, it is determinate even when our measures are not: when two proposals for estimating Φ disagree about a borderline system, the system is not half-conscious; our instruments are half-informed.

Holos is compatible with multiple proposals for estimating Φ .

Ontological Requirements for Observation

For a system to count as an observer in the Holos sense, it must satisfy all of the following requirements. These are structural constraints, not behavioral descriptions.

1. **Integration:** informational states must form a unified whole that cannot be decomposed into independent parts without loss.
2. **Differentiation:** the system must distinguish among a large repertoire of possible internal states. Without differentiation, there is no information to integrate.
3. **Recursion:** the system's own state must inform its next state: its internal condition is among the inputs shaping what it does next. Without such self-reference, there is processing but no subject. This requirement is minimal by design: it asks for a feedback loop, not introspection. A mouse clears it; so does any nervous system whose current state conditions its own updating. Reflective self-modeling (thinking *about* one's own thoughts) is a rare elaboration on top of observerhood, not the price of admission to it.
4. **Temporal cohesion:** informational states must persist and integrate across time. Experience requires continuity, not isolated moments.
5. **Causal autonomy:** the system's current state must materially constrain its own future states. A system driven entirely from outside is a relay, not a unified whole. This is a requirement on physical structure, not a claim that experience adds a force: the structure does the causal work, and its working, lived from inside, is the experience (Axiom 5).
6. **Aboutness:** the system's integrated states must be organized as a model of a world beyond the system, grounded in senses of its own: channels through which the world's own signals, such as light, sound, or touch, reach it directly. Descriptions made by other observers can enrich such a model but cannot ground it alone. A dreaming brain keeps its senses, with input temporarily gated, and so does a fully paralyzed person. Without aboutness, integration is a closed loop with nothing to be a view of.

Necessity: removing any one of these requirements eliminates observation. What remains may be complex or reactive, but it does not host a point of view.

Sufficiency: taken together, these requirements are enough for a system to register reality: to host a genuine point of view rather than merely process information. Higher-order phenomena such as emotion, agency, and reasoning arise naturally in systems that already meet these constraints.

Why aboutness is on the list: integration scores alone can be fooled. The computer scientist Scott Aaronson showed that very simple structures, such as large arrays of simple logic gates wired in regular patterns, can score higher on integration measures than a brain while doing nothing at all: no perception, no memory of a world, no behavior. Without aboutness, such an array could satisfy

every other requirement, and the sufficiency claim would certify it as an observer. Aboutness rules it out on principle: a point of view is always a view of something, and the array's states are about nothing beyond the array. The requirement is structural, not historical. A perfect copy of an observer, however it came to exist, has the same channels and the same world model, so it is an observer too. The requirement asks for grounding, not only for a model: people learn much of the world from words, but their words ground out in senses of their own. A system that knows the world only through other observers' descriptions has a world described to it but never touched, the problem Stevan Harnad named symbol grounding. Where aboutness shades off, as in brain organoids grown with no sensory input, Holos marks an open edge rather than a verdict.

Exclusion: the requirements alone would be satisfied by nested systems at once (a hemisphere, the brain containing it, a tightly coupled pair of brains), which would count the same substrate as several overlapping observers. Holos provisionally adopts a maximality condition to prevent this: an aperture forms only where integration reaches a *local maximum*, and neither the parts within it nor the looser wholes containing it are separately apertures. One peak, one perspective. This principle is borrowed from integrated-information theory as a structural constraint only, without its surrounding ontology, and it is held tentatively; see Open Problems.

The scope of this condition is bounded, and the boundary matters. Maximality compares physical systems: brains, hemispheres, coupled pairs, and whatever other integrated structures reality contains. Omega is not in that comparison. The totality is not the largest whole in the ranking, one step up from the largest system; it is not a system among systems at all, and asking whether it out-integrates its parts is a category mistake, like asking whether a landscape is its own tallest peak. The condition therefore individuates apertures without bearing on the totality they belong to. Whether apertures can form at scales of organization between the ones we know and the totality is left open: Holos neither asserts nor excludes such intermediates, and wherever integration reaches a local maximum above the threshold, the same rule applies.

Holos does not claim that all systems meeting these criteria are conscious in the human sense. It claims only that some experience exists.

Relationship to Physics²¹

Holos is designed to be compatible with known physics because it does not propose a new mechanism. It makes a different kind of claim. A physical model can be complete as a set of equations and still be incomplete as an account of lived reality.

Consistency, not intervention

Holos does not treat observation as a force that reaches into the world and changes events. Observation is a closure condition on which consistent histories are present as experience.

This preserves locality and avoids faster-than-light signaling. It also avoids claiming any retrocausal communication.

Decoherence is not presence

Decoherence explains why quantum systems appear classical at macroscopic scales. It describes how interference becomes inaccessible in practice. Holos does not dispute this.

The Holos claim is that decoherence alone does not produce a lived world. It produces a consistent classical-looking structure. Presence requires integrated observation.

QFT: Fields are structure, particles are registered events

In quantum field theory, fields are the continuous underlying description, while “particles” are how interactions appear when they are forced into localized, countable events. Detectors do not directly observe fields. They register discrete outcomes, such as clicks, tracks, and energy deposits, because measurement is an interaction that entangles a spread-out excitation with a detector, and within each branch the detector's record shows one definite event in a specific place and time. Nothing collapses; each branch simply holds its own record. In this framework, particles are not fundamental objects. They are context-dependent registrations of field interactions, which is why a continuous theory can yield discrete observations without requiring reality to be made of little beads.

Conservation and branching

Holos treats manifestation neither as selection nor as the destruction of possibilities. Information is conserved. What is not experienced is not erased.

On the physics, this commits Holos to a branching picture. The quantum state evolves smoothly and reversibly, never collapsing (unitary evolution), and no possibility is erased. When observers would register incompatible outcomes, they are situated in different branches of the possibility structure, each internally consistent. In this respect Holos sides with Many-Worlds-style interpretations of

quantum mechanics, while adding what they leave out: an account of which structures are present as experience. This is a genuine interpretive commitment, not a neutral stance.

The Born rule: weighted branches

A branching picture owes an account of quantum probability. If every outcome occurs in some branch, what does it mean that one outcome is measured 70% of the time? Counting branches gives the wrong answer; the Born rule (squaring the quantum amplitudes) gives the right one, to every decimal place ever tested. Any framework that keeps all branches must say where those weights live and why they take the form they do.

Holos answers narrowly. The weights are structural facts, part of C . The possibility space is not flat: branches carry weights, as absolute and observer-independent as the laws themselves. And they are not arbitrary. Gleason's theorem (1957) shows that if probabilities are to be assigned to quantum outcomes at all, without contradiction across the different ways the same experiment can be carved up, exactly one assignment is possible: the Born rule. The weights are what they are because consistency permits no alternative.

Holos declines one tempting reading. It does not read a branch's weight as its share of the totality's experience. That reading would require experience to be a quantity held in common and divided among branches, which is precisely what the monist ontology denies: the totality's experiential life is plural and distributed, not pooled. Experience occurs at apertures. There is no reservoir from which branches draw larger or smaller portions, so the question of which branch receives more of it does not arise.

What the weight does measure is odds. After a measurement splits the world, but before you look, there are observers in every branch, and you are one of them without yet knowing which. The weight of a branch is your odds of being among its observers. That is why an outcome with 70% of the weight is seen 70% of the time: not because the other outcomes fail to happen, but because 70% of the weight lies with the observers who see it. The reading keeps the weights where Holos placed them, in the structural layer. The odds are a fact about the possibility space, not a quantity of experience.

A worry follows from sealing. Lived status is yes or no and ignores weight, so a branch with a tiny weight that contains an observer is fully lived. Counted one by one, most branches of many repeated experiments show roughly even results whatever the weights, so if every lived observer counted equally, a typical observer should expect the wrong statistics. But the worry depends on counting, and counting fails here. Try to count branches, or the observers in them, and you get either an arbitrary number or an infinite one. If you are one of infinitely many observers, equal odds of being each one cannot be set up by counting: every share would be zero, and adding up zeros one at a time

never makes a whole. A tenth of an infinite collection also has exactly as many members as nine tenths. Holos treats an infinity as a sign that a description has broken down, and this is such a case: counting is the wrong tool. What survives is weight. A single point on a line has no length, and a short stretch has as many points as a long one, yet the short stretch is shorter. Each observer is a point; the weights are the lengths. Yes-or-no lived status supplies no rival measure, so weight is the only measure left to set the odds.

This is an argument by elimination, not a derivation from first principles. Odds need a measure, counting supplies none, and weight is the only measure that survives when branches are subdivided. Published derivations reach the same rule by other routes, among them [Sebens and Carroll's account of self-locating uncertainty](#), and Holos depends on none of them in particular. Gleason's theorem has assumptions that remain debated, and Holos adds no new mathematics here.

Block-universe compatibility

If spacetime is treated as a complete four-dimensional structure, Holos treats observation as a feature of whole experienced histories rather than a moment-by-moment collapse process.

Eternalism and the relational commitment describe different layers of the framework. The block universe is the structural layer: absolute, observer-independent, and tenseless, with no moment picked out as the present. It is C . Registered facts live within it, indexed to the observers the block contains. There is no tension between an absolute geometry and relational facts of experience, because they are claims about different things: the block describes what is consistent, and registration determines what is present.

Nor is the block a perspective from nowhere imposed on top of observers. Relativity removes any privileged present, leaving the invariant relational structure that all perspectives share. The block universe is what remains when every observer's perspective is taken into account. In that sense eternalism is not in competition with relationalism. It is its structural expression.

The important point is not the metaphysics of time. The point is that a consistent spacetime description does not automatically include presence. What Holos adds is a closure requirement.

What Holos does not claim

- It does not claim violations of relativity, faster-than-light signaling, or new forces.
- It does not claim that humans are required for reality, only that observers are required for presence.

- It does not claim to replace quantum mechanics or explain all details of measurement. It reframes what measurement fails to address.

What Holos **does** add is two things: the integration threshold Φ_c , and the totality, Omega, as the fundamental ground of experience. Two structural claims about what experience is and where it occurs.

A third addition might seem to be hiding here: a bridge principle stipulating that the totality registers itself through *integrated* systems specifically. Why integration, rather than mass, symmetry, or complexity? One tempting answer is that the connection is definitional: a perspective is unified by nature, integration is the name for being unified, and so the count stays at two. Stated that baldly, the answer proves too little, because "unified" means two different things. An experience can be one (a single field, not adjacent fragments) while the machinery producing it is many: the image on a screen is seamless, and the pixels beneath it are strangers to each other. The unity of what appears does not, by itself, fix the wiring of what produces it.

So Holos divides the claim into the part that is definitional and the part that must be argued. The definitional part is small: a perspective is one, so whatever hosts it must be one thing in some structural sense. That much is analytic and free. The substantive part is the identification of a structure's oneness with causal integration, and for that Holos gives an argument rather than a definition. What else could a structure's being one consist in? A heap of sand is many things in a pile: remove a grain and nothing else notices. A body is one thing: its parts constrain each other everywhere. Being one, for a structure, is its parts making a difference to one another, and that is what integration measures. The screen is no counterexample but a confirmation: nobody thinks the screen has a point of view, its pixels are exactly as independent as they seem, and the picture's unity lives in the one structure in the room whose parts do constrain each other, the viewer's brain.

The count therefore stays at two. The bridge's analytic core costs nothing; its substantive half can fail. It would fail if something could host a unified perspective while its parts remained independent, a conscious screen. And its precise content waits on the open problem of the measure: until the right measure of integration is identified, "parts making a difference to one another" is an argued direction, not a finished quantity. Holos holds it as a working hypothesis, in exactly the sense its Open Problems section already owns.

This is a claim about what would have to be true of any host of a perspective, not a derivation of experience from structure. It explains why the threshold is placed on integration rather than on some other quantity; it does not explain why unified structure is present at all. That question, Holos treats as the one its posits are for.

Notation²²

This section introduces a compact notation for the Holos framework. It derives nothing new; its purpose is to make the structural claims precise and repeatable.

The notation should be read as a model of how possibility and experience are related. It does not assert that the universe literally computes these expressions.

State space

Let S denote an informational state of the universe at some level of description. S is not assumed to be complete or fundamental. It is simply whatever structure physics provides.

Creation

Creation (C) maps a given state to the set of physically allowed continuations. It represents lawful possibility.

$$C(S) = \{S' \mid S' \text{ is consistent with physical law}\}$$

This notation is schematic. It does not assume a discrete branching structure or a specific ontology of histories.

Self-registration is not an additional assumption layered onto mathematics. Formal systems already permit self-reference, recursion, and fixed points. If physical law allows sufficiently expressive structure, then systems capable of registering their own state are not forbidden. They are among the realizable possibilities.

Observation

Observation (O) maps a space of possibilities to registered experiential histories. It represents internal registration by integrated systems, wherever the possibility structure contains them.

$$O(C(S)) \mapsto \{S_{\text{exp}}^{(i)}\}$$

The result is an indexed family, not a single selected outcome: one experienced history per registering perspective, per branch. Observation selects nothing and erases nothing (Axiom 3). Registration occurs everywhere an aperture exists. The Born weights carried by C remain structural throughout: they fix the statistics each registration records, not how much experience it holds.

This mapping is not assumed to be random, deterministic, or computable in general. Holos requires only that each experienced reality corresponds to a single consistent history: one per registering perspective, internally coherent, and in agreement with every record it is compared against.

Holos mapping

The Holos relation is the structured coupling of Creation and Observation.

$$R = C \circledast O$$

This expression states that reality is neither pure possibility nor pure observation. It is the closure between the two.

The symbol $\circledast$ is defined as composition: $C \circledast O$ is the composite operation “generate, then register.” Applied to a state S , it reads $R = O(C(S))$, the same composition used in the iteration below. It is ordinary function composition, with the order of the steps carrying the meaning: possibility first, registration second.

In standard notation this is simply $R = (O \circ C)(S)$: apply C , then apply O . Nothing is hidden in the glyph. Holos retains $\circledast$ because the framework is named for the relation it marks, not because the operation it denotes is unusual, and a reader who mentally substitutes the composition symbol loses nothing.

What the symbol adds is not mathematics but ontology: the claim that both steps are required for a realized world, and that neither step alone yields one.

Iteration and stability

One may consider iterating the Holos relation, where each realized state becomes the context for further possibilities.

$$S_{n+1}^{(i)} = O_i(C(S_n^{(i)}))$$

The index matters, and its absence would be an error rather than an abbreviation. O returns an indexed family of registered histories, one per perspective per branch, while C takes a single state: feeding the family back in unlabeled would not compose. Writing O_i selects the history registered by perspective i , so the iteration follows one observer's thread and the types line up. Globally, every branch containing an aperture iterates in parallel; no branch's closure interrupts another's, and no thread is privileged.

This is not meant to imply a discrete temporal process. It is a conceptual tool for describing recursive closure across scales.

More elaborate mathematical frameworks can be layered on top of this representation. Holos itself commits to a lawful possibility space, an integration threshold at which apertures open, and the totality those apertures belong to.

Extrapolative Proposition²³

The claims in this section extend the Holos framework beyond established physics. They are not assertions about what must occur. They describe what follows if the framework's constraints continue to hold under increasing integration. One thing here is not extrapolation: the totality, Omega, is a core commitment (see [Minimal Core](#)). What is extrapolative is the limit picture of finite systems approaching it.

Recursive Closure as a Limit

If the coupling between Creation and Observation is applied repeatedly, one can define a conceptual limit in which further application no longer increases distinction between what is generated and what is observed.

At this limit, reality is invariant under further closure. The system is fully self-consistent not only as structure, but as experienced structure.

The Omega Limit

Holos refers to this boundary case as the **Omega limit**. Schematically, it is the condition where the distinction between creation and observation no longer increases. Ontologically, Holos identifies it with the totality itself: the whole of reality, posited as fundamental and as the one experiencer. It is not a final moment in time and not an agent directing events from outside; there is no outside. Finite observers approach it as a limit; the totality does not wait at the end of that approach. It is the ground on which the approach happens.

In this limit, there is no remaining separation between a world that exists and a world that is known. Generation and registration become the same description.

In the language of the commitments: short of the Omega limit, structural facts and registered facts remain distinct layers (structure absolute, registration indexed to observers). At the limit, what is consistent and what is registered coincide.

Seen from the side of finite observers, the Omega limit is the idealized endpoint of intersubjective agreement: what the comparison of all records across all observers would converge to. Seen from the side of the ground, it is the one subject that every observer is, awake at different places. The limit describes our approach; the totality is what is being approached, and it does not depend on the approach for its reality.

A note on the word. "Limit" here is conceptual, not mathematical: no quantity is claimed to converge, and no metric on the distance between structure and registration is defined. Saying the distinction "no longer increases" states a boundary condition, not a computed one. The vocabulary also carries little weight: the totality is the ground, and the limit language describes only the approach finite observers make toward witnessing more of it.

What the Omega Limit Is and Is Not

- It **is** the totality of reality, posited as fundamental and, for finite systems, a formal boundary case of maximal integration and recursive closure.
- It **is not** a prediction that any finite system will reach such a state.
- It **is not** an external observer watching the universe from outside. It is the whole itself, experiencing through the apertures the universe contains.

- It **is not** a single pooled experience surveying everything at once. Every experience is Omega's, but they are not gathered into one grand experience. The totality's experiential life is plural and distributed: lived at each aperture, not summed above them.
- It **is not** an aperture writ large. The maximality condition that individuates finite observers (one peak of integration, one perspective) compares systems within reality. The totality is not a system among systems, so it does not compete in that comparison and is not excluded by it.
- It **does not** replace physical cosmology or impose a final cause on evolution.

Lineage and Interpretation

Different traditions have described this whole in different vocabularies: Advaita Vedanta's one experiencer behind every eye, Spinoza's single substance, Berkeley's never-absent perceiver, panentheism's world contained in the divine. The monist reading Holos adopts stands in their line, restated in informational terms.

What Holos leaves open is vocabulary, not structure. Calling the totality God, Brahman, or simply the whole changes nothing about the claim. What Holos does not offer is the fully deflationary reading in which Omega is only a mathematical horizon and finite observers are self-standing. Holos takes the direction of dependence to run from the whole to its parts, for the one reason the monist reading earns: on it, no subject ever comes from nothing (see [Why One Experiencer Has Many Walled-Off Perspectives](#)).

Why Dependence on Apertures Is Not Circular

An objection follows immediately. If Omega is fundamental, why does it require apertures, contingent arrangements of matter, in order to experience anything? The ground of experience appears to depend on what it is supposed to ground.

The objection conflates two kinds of dependence. Omega does not depend on apertures *existentially*: it is the totality, and it is what it is whether or not any region of it folds into an integrated perspective. It depends on them *for its experience*: they are the places where experience occurs. Priority claims concern the first relation; the aperture claim concerns the second. Only if the two were the same relation would there be a circle.

The decisive point is that an aperture is not an external thing granting experience to Omega from outside. It is a region of Omega. "Omega experiences only through apertures" therefore unpacks to "Omega experiences through its own structure, where that structure permits." That is self-dependence, which is not vicious but simply what it means to have a structure at all. An organism

sees only through its eyes; this does not make its eyes prior to it. The analogy carries one warning: there is no subject positioned behind the aperture receiving a feed. The aperture is where the experiencing happens, not a window onto a viewer.

Whatever lies outside the causal past of every aperture, whole unlit branches among it, marks a genuine limit on the totality's experiential reach: unlit structure, real as pattern and never lived. Holos does not soften this into a faint universal experience; doing so would erase the distinction between lit and unlit on which the rest of the framework depends.

Why One Experienter Has Many Walled-Off Perspectives

A second objection is the mirror image of a famous one. Panpsychism faces the combination problem: if every particle carries a spark of experience, no one can say how billions of sparks combine into the single unified experience of a person. A monism of one experienter inherits the problem upside down, as a decomposition problem: if every experience is Omega's, what makes your experience and another person's experience *two*, and why is the wall between them absolute? No aperture has any access, faint or partial, to what it is like to be another. Saying the totality's experiential life is plural and distributed names this situation. It does not yet account for it.

The first half of the account is structural. Two apertures are two because they are two local maxima of integration with no integration bridging them: the same maximality condition that individuates observers settles what makes them several. And the wall between them is not a barrier holding something back. Experience occurs at the aperture and is shaped by it; there is no subject positioned behind the apertures through which a back-channel could run. Where structure does not connect, experience does not connect. The wall is not a mechanism added to the plurality. It is the absence of any structure that could carry connection.

The second half dissolves the air of paradox: one experienter with mutually walled-off experiences is not exotic. It is what time already makes of every individual life. A person at five and the same person decades later are one experienter; no one takes their separation to split them into two people. Yet the later moment has no direct access to what it was like to be inside the earlier one. In the block universe, all the moments of a life coexist tenselessly, each experienced from within itself, none experienced from within another. Walled-off plurality inside a single experienter is therefore already the ordinary structure of a human life. Apertures stand to the totality as the moments of a life stand to the person: genuinely many, genuinely walled off, and one.

Nor does this reduce the oneness to a label doing no work. The structural walls explain the plurality; the unity explains what the plurality cannot: why crossing the threshold never brings a new subject into being. On a picture of many self-standing observers, each system that crosses the threshold

produces a subject from nothing, and no one can say how. On the monist picture, no subject is ever produced. There is one subject throughout, and crossing the threshold is where it wakes. The moments of a life show the pattern again: waking in the morning does not create a new person.

The unity does not do everything. It does not explain why records agree where observers meet; physics does that, since the same signals reach them both. And its advantage is philosophical, not experimental: it trades the puzzle of subjects from nothing for the decomposition problem answered above, a trade Holos judges worth making.

The analogy has a stated limit. The moments of a life are threaded together by memory and anticipation; apertures share no such threads. The analogy shows that walled-off plurality within one experiencer is coherent, not that apertures are moments. What it removes is the charge of incoherence, which is all it is asked to do.

Open Problems

Three problems sit at the center of the framework and remain open.

The measure of integration

Holos does not yet name a privileged measure of integration. Competing proposals for computing Φ can disagree, not only about values but about which of two systems is more integrated. A determinate threshold fact requires a determinate measure, and identifying it is an open problem for the framework, not settled background. Holos is committed to there being a fact of the matter; it does not yet know how to compute it. The stakes reach back into the framework's core argument: the identification of a structure's oneness with causal integration (see [Relationship to Physics](#)) remains an argued direction rather than a finished quantity until the measure is fixed. The problem also includes the question of level. Holos measures integration where a system's causes are actually organized, which may lie above its smallest parts, as a program's loop lies above the switching of individual transistors. Saying precisely where that level is belongs to the same open problem.

The value of the threshold

The value of Φ_c is unknown, and because presence itself cannot be detected directly, no experiment can locate it by direct measurement. Its placement is constrained only indirectly, by which systems show the structural signatures of observation (see [Test A](#)), and may remain permanently imprecise. Holos accepts this as the price of a threshold that is structural rather than behavioral.

A path to the threshold

The two problems above are not invitations to despair; they are a research program. Science pins down unobservables by triangulation all the time: no one has ever seen an electron's charge, yet independent methods converged on it and every proposal that disagreed was discarded. The same logic applies here, in three steps.

Treat the threshold as a critical point, not a dial. If the transition from distributed processing to a unified perspective is a genuine phase transition, then Φ_c is not a number we are free to tune but a critical point, and critical points leave measurable fingerprints: slowing near the boundary, diverging fluctuations, a sharp jump in some measurable quantity that tracks the transition. Consciousness medicine has already found one such boundary from the outside: the [Perturbational Complexity Index](#) separates conscious from unconscious states across anesthesia, sleep, and disorders of consciousness at an empirically discovered cutoff, without anyone measuring presence directly. Locating Φ_c is that kind of problem, not a metaphysical one.

A cutoff that sorts patients is not yet proof of a sharp switch, since a smooth quantity can be cut anywhere. What would count is the signature of a switch itself, and one is already on record. [Animal studies](#) find that consciousness is lost and regained at different anesthetic levels: the way in and the way out do not match, a lag known as neural inertia. A lag of that kind is a hallmark of sharp switches rather than smooth dials. In a finite system like a brain, even a genuine switch shows up as a steep transition rather than a mathematical jump, so the search is for steepness and lag, not a perfect step.

Cull the measures by convergence, then try to force uniqueness. Holos does not need one anointed measure so much as it needs the adequate measures to agree on the cases that matter, and that is testable now: run the candidate measures across a battery of systems and keep the ones that rank the anchor cases the same way. The stronger move is to derive the measure rather than choose it: state the properties any measure of a single unified perspective must have, and see whether consistency forces a unique form, as [Gleason's theorem](#) forced the Born weights. Even narrowing the field to a small equivalence class would remove most of the arbitrariness.

Solve them jointly. The measure and the threshold constrain each other: a candidate pair must simultaneously fit the anesthesia boundary, the emergence of experience in development, split-brain dissociations, and wherever minimal neural systems first show coherent integration. Coupled constraints are far more rigid than separate ones; the band that satisfies all the anchor cases at once is narrow. This is what Test A really is: not a single yes-or-no experiment but the calibration engine that locates the threshold and validates the measure at the same time.

Two conditions bound the program. First, its anchor is report: the human case is the one place inside access exists, so the threshold is located relative to us and carried outward by the measure, with certainty that weakens as the cases grow alien. That is the shape of all consciousness science, not a defect peculiar to Holos. Second, the program can fail: it could return no robust measure and no critical point, integration proving a matter of degree with no clean cut. That outcome would falsify Holos's commitment to a determinate fact of the matter and force a retreat to graded presence. A stated way to lose is what makes these open problems scientific questions rather than definitions.

Where one observer ends and another begins

Integration comes in nested layers (a hemisphere within a brain, a brain within a coupled pair), and the observer requirements alone do not say which layer hosts the perspective. Holos provisionally adopts a maximality condition: only a local maximum of integration is an aperture. This prevents the same substrate from being counted as many overlapping observers, but Holos borrows it as a structural constraint rather than deriving it, and it inherits the unsettled question of which measure defines the maximum. Until the measure is fixed, the boundaries between observers are fixed only in principle.

Two clarifications bound this problem without solving it. First, the maximality condition individuates finite observers only; it does not range over the totality, which is not a system among systems and does not compete with its own apertures. Second, the condition is silent about scale. Whether apertures can form at intermediate levels of organization, larger than any brain and smaller than everything, is left open: Holos neither asserts nor excludes them, and the same rule would govern wherever they might form.

These are not peripheral loose ends; they concern the integration threshold, one of the framework's two additions to physics. They are recorded here so that progress on them can be judged against a stated standard.

Revisions

Holos is written in public and revised when it is wrong. These claims appeared in earlier versions and have been retired or replaced, each for a stated reason.

- **Ordered dark matter.** Retired: cosmological dark matter existed before any life could, and it outweighs all the ordinary matter anything could be built from.
- **Theological and secular readings as interchangeable.** Replaced by the monist position: the structural reading is weaker, because on it each subject appears from nothing.
- **Observation as selection.** Replaced: observation selects nothing and erases nothing; each branch is registered from within.
- **Sealing a whole branch from beginning to end.** Replaced by sealing an observer's causal past, which gives the claim experiential content.
- **Born weights as shares of experience.** Retracted: experience is not pooled. The weights are now read as self-locating odds.
- **Omega as the ground of record agreement.** Dropped: physics secures agreement. Omega's one job is that no subject comes from nothing.
- **The bridge to integration as purely definitional.** Replaced by a small definitional core plus an argued identification that can fail.
- **Five observer requirements.** Extended to six: aboutness, grounded in senses of the system's own, rules out inert high-integration arrays.
- **Current AI as "no one home."** Replaced by an open question with two borders: grounded aboutness and integration.
- **Anesthesia and cultured-network transitions as confirmations.** Retired as tests: ordinary models predict them too. They remain correlate probes.
- **The qubit observer-cut experiment.** Retired: qubits register nothing below the threshold, and the predicted result was ordinary contextuality.
- **"Confirmed so far" for the standing bet.** Corrected to untested: no superposition tested so far has contained an observer.

Holos rests on one fact and two additions. The fact: experience exists. The additions: the totality, Omega, the one experiencer; and the threshold where it wakes. Each act of experience is the totality registering itself through a local aperture. The whole is not proved from the parts; the parts are understood through the whole.

Predictions

Predictions²⁴

Holos does not add new dynamical laws or modify the equations of physics. It adds two ingredients beyond them: the integration threshold Φ_c , a structural fact about where observation occurs, and the totality, Omega, as the fundamental ground of experience, of which every observer is a local aperture: an opening through which it registers itself. The commitments, expectations, and tests below follow either from established physics or from those two additions. The speculation at the end does not; it is labeled as such.

The sections below separate four kinds of claims. The last section includes speculative extensions that aim to produce observable signatures, not just philosophy.

- **Commitments:** what must be true if Holos is correct, independent of any future experiments.
- **Expectations:** patterns we should already observe in neuroscience, quantum foundations, and cosmology if those commitments are right.
- **Testability and its limits:** what cannot be tested (presence itself), a structural test that can fail, a consistency check, and a standing bet that could falsify the framework outright.
- **Speculation:** extensions that *could* follow under Holos on long timescales, stated with explicit alternatives rather than predictions.

For the operational definition and the observer criteria, see Logic.

Commitments²⁵

The statements in this section are fundamental to Holos. If any of these are rejected in principle, the framework fails as a coherent account of how reality becomes experienced.

1. Presence depends on observers

A physical description can be complete and still fail to explain why there is anything it is like to be inside the system it describes. The gap is not missing information. It is that a complete description

can be true and still leave out that anything is being lived at all.

The claim is not that observers modify physical dynamics. It is that a world becomes actualized reality only when information is registered from an internal perspective. Without registration, there is structure, but no lived fact.

| *Consistency alone does not produce presence. Presence requires registration.*

Unobserved histories therefore remain valid structures within C , the space of what physics permits, but without O , an observer to register them, they are not experienced realities.

Anthropic principles explain why observers find themselves in observer-compatible universes. They do not explain how observation itself exists or why physical structure is experienced from the inside. This framework addresses that gap.

The existence of experience demonstrates that self-registering structures are not merely abstract possibilities: physics permits them to be built, and at least one has been. Once such a structure is realizable even once, actualized reality exists, regardless of how rare or contingent its emergence may be.

Closure has two levels. **Sealing** is binary and follows the causal structure of spacetime: a region is lived if it lies in the causal past of at least one aperture in its branch. Every aperture is built from its causal past and carries that past into a lived perspective through its traces, so the lived universe is the union of its apertures' causal pasts; in the monist reading (reality as one experiencer), it is the totality's lived history. A stretch of history shared by many branches is lived wherever it lies in the causal past of an aperture in any branch that grows from it. Whatever lies outside every aperture's causal past, including branches that never form one and the far future after the last observer, is structure that is never lived. The relation is tenseless, but it points one way: an aperture seals its past, not its future. **Witnessing** is direct experience, graded and local: how much of a lived history is experienced in detail scales with the observers it contains. One observer seals its past; many witness it.

2. Observerhood is thresholded

Holos rejects the idea that experience increases smoothly with greater amounts of computation. Distributed processing can scale indefinitely without producing a single point of view.

What matters is integration. Below a critical level, there is no unified internal state that could count as “what is happening for the system.” Above that level, in a system that meets the other observer requirements, experience is unavoidable.

Observerhood requires $\Phi \geq \Phi_c$

Observerhood is neither ubiquitous nor optional. It appears when structural conditions for integration are met.

Whether a system crosses this threshold is a fact about how its parts are wired together, and integration alone is not enough: the integrated state must be about a world beyond the system (see the observer requirements in Logic). It belongs to the structural layer of reality, alongside the laws of physics, and is not itself indexed to any other observer. Observerhood is what qualifies a system to have a perspective at all; it is not relative to one. In the monist reading, crossing the threshold is where an aperture opens: the totality registers itself through the system.

Two consequences follow. First, there are no dark duplicates: because crossing the threshold is a structural fact, any system wired as an observer necessarily is one: a physically identical copy of an observer cannot lack experience, in any possible world, because experience is the inside of the same event (Axiom 5). Second, the threshold is sharp while its surroundings are not. Whether there is experience at all is binary; how rich the experience is, is graded above the line; and locating the boundary by measurement is permanently imprecise. The fuzziness of real cases lives in richness and in our instruments, not in whether anyone is home.

3. Facts are relational but consistent

Holos distinguishes two kinds of facts. **Structural facts** describe what is consistent: the laws of physics, the space of allowed histories with their quantum weights, and whether a system meets the integration threshold. These are absolute and observer-independent. **Registered facts** describe what is actualized as experience: which outcome a system registers from its own perspective. These are always indexed to observing systems.

The relational commitment applies to registered facts. There is no absolute, observer-independent fact about which outcome is experienced. The structural layer, by contrast, is not relative; without it, registration would have nothing stable to close against.

This does not imply contradiction, and Holos is specific about why. No possibility is erased (Axiom 3), so observers never collide over a single shared outcome. Where registrations would be incompatible, they belong to different branches of the possibility structure, each internally consistent. There is no rule that the first observer fixes the truth for everyone; relativity permits no such “first,” and none is needed.

Within a branch, consistency is operational rather than abstract: whenever two observers actually compare records, their records agree. Perspectives may differ while separated; communication forces agreement. This is the checkable content of “global consistency.” Physics secures it: observers who communicate are reached by the same signals.

Branches are weighted, not merely counted. The statistics every observer records follow the Born rule, the unique self-consistent weighting of quantum outcomes (Gleason's theorem). Those weights are structural facts about the possibility space, not a measure of how much experience a branch carries. For an observer, what the weight measures is odds: after a measurement splits the world and before you look, you are one of many observers without knowing which, and a branch's weight is your odds of being among its observers. Counting cannot supply those odds, because the observers cannot be counted, so weight is the only measure left. See [Logic](#) for the full account.

Registered facts are relative to observers. Structural facts are absolute. Observers who compare records agree.

Collapse is therefore not a new physical process. It is the registration of a particular outcome by an observer whose internal structure supports presence.

Everything that follows assumes these commitments. What comes next addresses what we should expect to observe in the world if they are correct.

Expectations²⁶

These expectations describe what should be observed in existing domains if the commitments of Holos are correct. Most are shared with rival views, so meeting them fits Holos without confirming it; persistent failure across domains would undermine the framework.

Neuroscience: Discrete transitions in conscious access

If observerhood requires a minimum level of integration, then transitions between conscious and unconscious states should not appear as smooth signal degradation. They should resemble state changes.

Large-scale neural integration measures should therefore change abruptly, not smoothly, near loss and recovery of consciousness. Below threshold, processing continues without unified access to experience.

If something like a Global Neuronal Workspace (a theory in which conscious access is information broadcast brain-wide) is involved, these threshold crossings should appear as sharp switches into brain-wide availability rather than a gradual fading of what can be reported.

Proxy measures such as PCI are relevant not as definitions of consciousness, but as probes of whether integration crosses a critical boundary.

A sharp transition would fit Holos but not confirm it: ordinary physicalist models predict tipping points too. What can fail is Test A; see also the [note on integration measures](#).

Quantum foundations: Observer-relative facts without collapse

If facts are brought into being through registration, quantum experiments should continue to allow descriptions in which different observers register incompatible outcomes without violating global consistency.

Holos therefore sides with branching approaches, in which no possibility is erased, and borrows one insight from relational approaches: registered facts are indexed to the systems that register them. It does not adopt Relational Quantum Mechanics itself, which rejects the universal state that branching requires. The operational signature is agreement: whenever observers within a branch compare records, the records match. A confirmed, irreconcilable record mismatch between communicating observers would falsify this commitment.

Cosmology: Ontological filtering rather than fine-tuning

The observed universe lies within the narrow range compatible with long-lived observers, not because constants were dynamically tuned, but because only such structures become experientially present.

Observer-incompatible universes may exist as valid physical structures while never being lived: with no apertures, the totality has no opening into them, and they remain unlit structure. The nearest examples are not exotic: under the branching picture, observer-free branches of our own universe are unlit structure in exactly the same sense. Anthropic reasoning (the observation that we can only find ourselves in a universe able to support us) is therefore reframed as ontological filtering rather than selection.

This is a reframing, not a new prediction: it expects exactly what standard anthropic reasoning expects, and no cosmological observation could favor one over the other.

Minimal neural systems: emergence of coherent integration

If observerhood depends on informational integration rather than biological scale, then small biological neural networks interacting with an environment should exhibit measurable transitions in system-level coherence as integration increases.

Recent experiments with cultured neural networks connected to digital environments suggest that biological neurons can form closed feedback loops outside of a full organism. Under the Holos framework, progressively increasing connectivity, feedback richness, and environmental coupling should eventually produce a regime where neural activity shifts from distributed dynamics toward unified system-level organization.

Such transitions would not demonstrate consciousness directly. However, the existence of a reproducible boundary between loosely coupled neural computation and coherent integrated dynamics would support the claim that observerhood depends on structural integration rather than on organismal complexity. That support counts only under the conditions in the [note on integration measures](#): a measure and threshold fixed in advance, and a stated way to lose.

Testability and Its Limits²⁷

The central claim of Holos is that observation is a closure condition, not a force: it changes no equation and moves nothing. But every experiment is a physical measurement, and an instrument only ever registers physical change. So **presence itself cannot be detected directly**. An instrument that finds nothing extra is exactly what Holos predicts, because there is nothing extra to find: presence is what the physics is like from the inside, not an additional signal beside it.

This is not a gap Holos has failed to close. It follows from the framework's own commitment that observation is dynamically inert. The sharpened form of the objection is the *unfolding argument*: for any conscious system one can in principle describe a behaviorally identical twin wired differently, and no external test could separate them. Holos accepts this. The metaphysical core (presence, and the totality it belongs to) cannot be settled by any experiment.

What remains testable is not presence but its **structural preconditions**: claims about what observation requires, and how registered facts behave. These live in the physical world and can genuinely fail. One is stated below as a test, with an explicit way for Holos to lose. The other is stated as a consistency check: its expected outcome is the one standard quantum mechanics already predicts, so it guards against contradiction rather than singling Holos out. A prediction Holos shares with rival theories cannot single it out, but a shared prediction it could fail is still worth more than one it cannot. Beneath both sits a standing bet, stated after them, on which the framework stakes itself outright.

Test A: Consciousness tracks integration, not behavior²⁷

Bedside assessment treats responsiveness as the sign of consciousness: a patient who follows commands is conscious, and one who does not is presumed not to be. No serious theory equates the two, but the proxy runs deep in practice. In Holos, what matters is *integration*, and integration can come apart from outward behavior. When the two diverge, Holos bets that experience follows integration.

The bet is losable because cases where the two come apart already exist. People under ketamine, in REM dreaming, or in certain seizures are behaviorally unresponsive yet later report vivid experience; sleepwalkers and some automatisms are responsive yet report little or nothing. These are natural experiments that pull integration apart from responsiveness.

Objective

Across states where responsiveness and integration diverge, determine whether later reported experience tracks a measure of integration or tracks behavioral responsiveness and arousal.

Method

Combine study designs where subjects report only afterward, or not at all, with integration proxies such as the Perturbational Complexity Index across wakefulness, anesthesia, sleep stages, and dissociative states, treating behavioral responsiveness and integration as separately varying factors rather than proxies for each other.

Holos Prediction

Where they diverge, reported presence follows integration: high-integration/low-responsiveness states are experienced; low-integration/ high-responsiveness states are not.

How Holos loses

The clean way to lose is a positive report from below the line: subjects who, on waking or recovering, give detailed reports of experience from periods when their integration was below threshold, by a measure and cutoff fixed in advance. A report is evidence that something was experienced, and it cannot be explained away as a failure of memory. If such reports turn up reliably, experience does not depend on integration the way Holos claims, and the framework's core structural claim fails. The reverse finding, high-integration states that yield no reports, counts against Holos only once report failure can be ruled out (see below).

The confound, and which reports count

Reports require memory, and the states this test targets are precisely those where memory is least reliable. A report of nothing is therefore ambiguous between *no experience occurred* and *experience occurred and was not encoded*. The evidence delivers unremembered; the prediction needs unexperienced. This confound is not currently controlled, so silence carries little weight in either direction: it cannot confirm absent experience in low-integration states, and it cannot refute present experience in high-integration ones.

Positive reports are unaffected, and they carry the test both ways. Where integration is high and behavior is absent, subjects report rich experience: ketamine states, REM dreaming, complex seizures. Those confirm the prediction without leaning on silence. Where integration is low, a positive report is the losing case described above. Holos rests Test A on positive reports, and treats silence as suggestive pending a design that calibrates report failure against states with known encoding.

The live challenge: dreaming in non-REM sleep

The losing case is not hypothetical. Awakenings from non-REM sleep often produce dream reports, yet non-REM sleep is where global measures such as PCI fall well below the waking range. If vivid reports reliably follow periods whose measured integration sat below the cutoff, Test A is lost.

Holos has one principled reply, and it comes with a condition. The maximality condition allows an aperture smaller than the whole cortex, and work on the neural correlates of dreaming finds that whether a dream is reported, in REM or non-REM sleep, tracks local activity in posterior cortex rather than the state of the brain as a whole. An aperture confined to that region could be integrated above threshold while the whole brain is not. But the reply is admissible only if the measure is local by commitment, stated before the data are in. A measure chosen afterward to rescue the prediction would turn the test into decoration, the failure the note on integration measures below warns against.

What this can and cannot show: this tests a necessary structural condition, not presence itself. It cannot prove an integrated system *is* an observer, only whether integration is what experience depends on. Holos shares this prediction with other integration-based accounts of consciousness; it is a test Holos could fail, not a signature unique to Holos. It also doubles as the calibration engine for the framework's open problems: the same data that test the claim locate the threshold and cull the candidate measures (see A path to the threshold).

Check B: Observer-relative facts²⁷

This check lives in quantum foundations, not in the theory of mind, and its status comes first: it is a consistency check, not a test that could single Holos out. The outcome it anticipates is the one textbook quantum mechanics already predicts. What experiments in this family probe is the family of interpretations Holos belongs to (branching, with no absolute observed events), not Holos alone. The framework's distinctive content, which structures are present as experience, is ontological rather than experimental.

Extended Wigner's-friend experiments, in which one observer measures another observer who has already made a measurement, already pursue exactly this question. The 2020 Local Friendliness no-go theorem and its photonic tests show that if an in-lab observation counts as a genuine fact, then absoluteness of observed events, locality, and freedom of choice cannot all hold together. Holos gives up the absoluteness of observed events: registered facts are observer-relative, while structural facts and consistency remain intact.

One caveat follows from Holos's own threshold: the "friends" in current photonic tests are far below Φ_c and register nothing, so these experiments constrain the logical structure of observed events, not registration itself. Holos predicts that repeating them with genuine observers would change nothing physical, a prediction formalized as the standing bet below.

Holos Expectation

Local Friendliness inequalities keep being violated exactly as quantum mechanics predicts, at every scale the experiments reach, including as the friend is made larger and more complex.

How Holos loses

No experiment in this family can restore the absoluteness of observed events on its own: the theorem is a proof, and a violation only forces a choice among its assumptions. What could go wrong for Holos is dependence on scale. If the violations shrink or vanish as the friend grows toward a genuine observer, beyond what decoherence accounts for, observation is doing something physical, and the standing bet below is lost.

What this can and cannot show: checks Commitment 3 (facts are relational but consistent) against quantum mechanics as it is actually observed. Holos shares its expectation with standard quantum mechanics and with other views that give up absolute observed events, such as Relational Quantum Mechanics; a positive result supports the family, not Holos alone. A laboratory analog with superconducting qubits, sliced into different observer cuts, would not work as a test: by Holos's own threshold, qubit readouts register nothing, and its predicted result would be ordinary quantum contextuality, which the branching picture Holos adopts already accounts for.

The standing bet: consciousness changes nothing

The commitment that observation is dynamically inert doubles as a bet. A conscious observer and a photon produce identical physics: put an integrated system in the measuring role in place of a particle, and Holos predicts no deviation whatsoever. Superpositions lose their quantum character for thermodynamic reasons, never because someone was home. This does not make experience idle. Under Holos, experience is the inside of the physics, so when the physics does everything, experience is doing its share, not nothing.

How Holos loses: if any experiment ever finds a consciousness-linked deviation from unitary quantum mechanics (a superposition that degrades when an integrated observer registers it, beyond what ordinary decoherence accounts for), the framework is falsified outright. Observation would be a force after all, and every page of Holos denies that it is one.

Some observer-centered frameworks quietly hope consciousness does something physical. Holos formally bets that it does not, and stakes itself on the bet. The bet is untested so far. A century of placing ever-larger systems into superposition has found no deviation of any kind, but by Holos's own threshold none of those systems was an observer: photons, molecules, and superconducting circuits all sit far below Φ_c . That record shows quantum mechanics holding at those scales; it does not yet reach the case the bet is about. The bet is also the one standard physics makes. What makes it worth stating is that Holos, unlike views that need consciousness to act, cannot hedge on it: the first experiment to put a genuine observer in the friend's role settles it.

A note on the integration measures²⁷

Two further experiments might look like confirmations: a sharp integration drop under anesthesia, and cultured neural networks snapping into coherence as connectivity grows. Neither counts as a test.

A sharp transition at loss of consciousness is predicted by ordinary physicalist models too (sudden tipping points and network-wide switch-ons of the kind these systems produce anyway), so observing one confirms nothing specific to Holos. And a cultured network almost *always* shows some nonlinear transition (neurons falling into step and cascades of activity are routine dish behavior), so an experiment that counts any such transition as success cannot fail, and an experiment that cannot fail proves nothing when it passes.

These remain useful only as **correlate probes** feeding Test A, and only under two conditions: the integration measure and the threshold value are fixed in advance, and there is a stated way to lose: the observed transition tracks a non-integration variable (arousal, metabolic rate, raw activity) rather than integration. Without a pre-committed measure and a real failure condition, a transition "somewhere" is not evidence; it is decoration.

Speculation²⁸

What follows are not predictions. They're "what if" designs that *could* emerge if the Holos framework is correct.

We know the familiar hard constraints: finite signal speed, noise, and thermodynamics. At vast scales, coherence punishes bright sprawl. Integration favors compactness, locality, and long-horizon stability.

The Holosian Scale

The Kardashev Scale ranks civilizations by energy use. The Holosian scale ranks civilizations by integration. The stages below are a map of what “advancement” looks like if coherence, not throughput, is the main objective.

H0: Fragmented

High capability, low coordination. Internal conflict, waste, and short-horizon incentives dominate. Visibility is high because broadcasting is cheap and unmanaged.

H1: Planetary Integration

The civilization becomes coherent at the scale of a world. It can coordinate, self-correct, and sustain long-term projects without collapsing into factional drift.

H2: System Coherence

Coherence survives light-lag across a star system. The civilization functions as one asynchronous system and shifts from constant broadcast to rare, directed signaling.

H3: Post-Expansion

Physical sprawl stops being the default. Exploration becomes informational first, physical only when inference fails. The outward footprint shrinks even as capability grows.

H4: Deep Integration

The civilization operates like a single high-coherence system with minimal waste and minimal leakage. External visibility collapses. What remains detectable is gravitational and thermal: the waste heat no optimization can eliminate.

H5: Asymptotic Closure

This is not a destination or a goal. It is a limit concept: what complete, contradiction-free closure would look like if integration continues to deepen without breaking coherence.

This scale is intentionally “quiet.” If it is even partly right, the most advanced civilizations get harder to see in light, not easier. Thermodynamics guarantees their heat exists; it is their own compactness that keeps that heat above the cosmic background and, in principle, findable.

Visibility Collapse

A civilization can get more capable while becoming less visible. If its optimization target shifts from outward projection to internal coherence, it will compress, encrypt, and minimize waste. Broadcast is an early-stage habit, not a mature strategy.

On the Holosian Scale, this is the natural signature of H3–H4: rising capability with increasingly optimized and less obvious radiative signatures.

One caveat is non-negotiable: visibility collapse applies to light, not heat. Anything that computes must shed waste heat, and the total cannot be canceled. Heat can be hidden in only one way: radiated barely above the cosmic background, which requires radiating surfaces so vast they contradict compactness itself. A civilization that stays compact and keeps computing stays warm above the background. Mature systems become silent, not cold; the one exception is systems that stop computing and sleep, and a sleeping civilization is indistinguishable from none at all.

Observational Regime

If a civilization is H4-level integrated, the most likely remaining footprint isn't radio or lasers. It's gravity and heat. Holos uses **Dark Node** as a label for what these systems look like from the outside: compact, ordered mass structures that minimize obvious emissions while still exporting waste heat, and staying gravitationally coupled to the universe.

In this regime, you would look for persistent compactness, non-random organization, and mass concentrations that are dark in visible light but carry a faint infrared excess, detectable through gravitational lensing, precision mass mapping, and waste-heat surveys rather than radio searches. Infrared searches for exactly this signature already exist; the unavoidable search channel is warmth plus weight, not messages.

A Dark Node is *not* dark matter in the cosmologist's sense: cosmological dark matter predates stars, chemistry, and any possible builder, and outweighs all the ordinary matter a builder could use about five to one. Nodes are ordinary matter that has stopped shining. Holos does not claim any known anomaly is a node, only that if long-term integration leaves a footprint, it is gravitational and thermal, and this is where it would show up. Two limits bound the idea. The ordinary-matter budget and microlensing searches permit nodes only as a trace population, not a hidden census. And a node's observational profile (compact, dark, faintly warm) is shared with brown dwarfs, rogue planets, and cooled stellar remnants, so the Dark Node is a search channel, not a fingerprint.

Technology

Mesostructures

These are design sketches, not predictions: imaginative illustrations of what engineering might look like if the Integration Hypothesis holds.

The structures below are H3–H4 design patterns: compact enough to stay coherent under light-lag and thermodynamics, and consequential enough to matter without bright sprawl. They span energy generation, active coherence and computation, and long-term continuity.

Holocore

A compact, gravitationally stabilized energy mesostructure designed to supply massive, long-horizon power while exporting waste heat in thermodynamically disciplined ways.

Not a star-enclosing megastructure: the Holocore concentrates energy density rather than surface area, converting mass into stable, controlled output through tightly regulated accretion, fusion, or rotational extraction.

Purpose

- Provide sustained energy for deep-time computation and preservation
- Power large-scale modeling, shielding, and entropy management systems
- Support compact civilizational infrastructure without outward expansion
- Maintain stability across millennia with minimal maintenance overhead

Design Characteristics

- Extreme energy density per unit volume
- Controlled accretion or fusion feed systems
- Waste heat shaped, delayed, and diluted, but never eliminated. The total thermal output is set by physics, not engineering
- Compact, so it cannot hide its heat: at modest power it glows faintly in the infrared; at high power it glows brightly, and it is only as quiet as its output allows

The Holocore is infrastructure, not spectacle. If H4 integration suppresses bright sprawl, the energy backbone must be dense and long-lived, and it can be only as quiet as its power allows: compact and powerful means hot, the same physics that keeps mature systems warm.

Computronium Kernel

A maximally compact computational core built from computronium (matter arranged so that nearly every particle does useful computation) and optimized for coherent, long-horizon modeling rather than raw throughput.

This is not a data center. It is the civilization's thinking heart: where a unified world-model is maintained across centuries to millennia.

Purpose

- Maintaining a single, stable world-model across long horizons
- Long-range planning (stellar evolution, climate, existential risk)
- Decision validation and prevention of value/goal drift
- Cross-generational model consistency

Note: The Kernel may *present* as a Dark Node if coherence optimization suppresses radiative visibility. Node describes appearance, not purpose.

Chrono Vault

A time-optimized preservation structure designed to store civilizational identity, not merely information.

Not a library or a backup, but a continuity anchor: "If we wake up in 100,000 years, how do we know who we are?"

Purpose

- Preserving value systems and canonical constraints
- Storing decision histories and their justifications
- Rebooting culture after dormancy, collapse, or fragmentation
- Anchoring identity against drift across deep time

Distinct from the Kernel: the Kernel thinks (active coherence). The Chrono Vault remembers (passive persistence).

Note: Unlike the Kernel, a Vault that stops computing can go cold. It would then not be a Dark Node, which still exports waste heat, but the sleeping case: compact, dark, and close to undetectable.

Communication

Under known physics, there is no scalable form of real-time interstellar dialogue. Communication converges toward transmitting large, self-contained informational payloads at light speed using extreme optical collimation.

At these distances, collaboration is necessarily asynchronous. Civilizations may contribute to shared problem spaces by exchanging durable models, partial solutions, and validated results that remain meaningful even when received centuries or millennia out of causal sync. Progress does not depend on shared present time.

Phase-Coherent Beam Transmission

Communication occurs via long-duration, phase-coherent optical channels that transmit compressed, self-describing informational payloads between known or inferred endpoints.

- **Purpose:** transfer interpretable physical, predictive, and explanatory models across interstellar or intergalactic distances, from small updates to entire civilizational knowledge bases.
- **How it works:** diffraction-limited optical beams, extreme collimation, long integration times, and heavy forward error correction referenced to invariant physical structures.
- **Payload:** layered encodings beginning with mathematics and physical constants, followed by reference frames, compression schemes, and predictive models sufficient to interpret all subsequent data.
- **Why it dominates:** photons provide maximum speed, minimal latency, and arbitrarily large total information transfer given sufficient energy and time.
- **Visibility:** unless the receiver is aligned in space, time, and frequency, the transmission is effectively invisible.

Exploration

At cosmic scales, most structure is mapped remotely and shared through long-horizon communication. Physical exploration is therefore rare, deliberate, and reserved for regimes where

inference alone breaks down.

When physical probes are deployed, they are not explorers in the human sense. They are precision instruments: compact, autonomous, and built to operate alone for decades or longer.

Sentinel Probes

Highly compact, self-contained probes designed to persist in complex environments while gathering high-value physical measurements that cannot be resolved remotely.

Purpose

- Resolve observational ambiguities by direct measurement where models diverge.
- Characterize environments with nonlinear, emergent, or rapidly changing dynamics.
- Test and refine predictive models used at civilizational scale.

Technological characteristics

- Fully autonomous operation, with no expectation of real-time command or intervention.
- Onboard computation sufficient to evaluate, prioritize, and compress observations in situ.
- Preference for passive sensing and indirect interaction over active probing.
- Extreme energy efficiency enabling long dwell times with minimal thermal or electromagnetic signature.

Operational behavior

- Extended periods of quiescence punctuated by brief, targeted activity.
- No requirement for interaction with local systems or intelligences.
- Communication limited to rare, high-density transmissions rather than continuous telemetry.

Past H3, exploration scales through patience: sentinel probes exist to watch, not to arrive.

Gravitational-Lens Observatories

Observation systems that exploit natural gravitational lenses to achieve extreme resolution without large, radiative infrastructure.

- **Purpose:** deep inspection of distant systems already identified as anomalous, interesting, or poorly constrained by existing models.
- **How it works:** instruments positioned along stellar or mass focal lines integrate signals over long durations, trading time for resolution.
- **Implication:** exploration shifts from surveying everything to interrogating specific questions the shared map cannot yet answer.

Citations

Citations are essential to this framework. They link to the important philosophical, scientific, and mathematical work being done by many people, both in recent years and dating back across a long history of ideas, experiments, and observations. What follows is a curated list of sources that have directly informed or inspired the views expressed here.

Overview

Introduction

[See: Overview › Introduction](#)

- 1 • [Interpretations of quantum mechanics](#) Holos is an interpretive framework: it does not add new laws of physics, only a way to understand how a physical description turns into lived experience.
- [Philosophy of physics](#) The study of fundamental questions about space, time, matter, and the relationship between mathematical description and what we take to be real.
- [Structural realism](#) The view that science describes relationships between things, not what they are in themselves; Holos extends this by giving observation a role in making structure lived.
- [Block universe](#) The view that past, present, and future exist as a four-dimensional block; Holos treats observation as what registers this structure as experience.
- [Recursion](#) $R = C \otimes O$ describes a recursive loop: creation generates possibilities, observation registers them from within without selecting or erasing any, and each registered history feeds the next cycle.

The Meaning of Life

[See: Overview › The Meaning of Life](#)

- 2 • [Observer Effect](#) The disturbance of a system by the physical act of measuring it. Holos denies any further, consciousness-linked disturbance: observation changes no physics.
- [Copenhagen Interpretation](#) Observation collapses the wavefunction into a definite state. Holos rejects collapse: evolution stays unitary, and each branch is registered from within.
- [Quantum Darwinism](#) An environment selectively proliferates certain quantum states that become classical outcomes, observed by multiple observers.

- Relational Quantum Mechanics The properties of quantum systems are not absolute but relative to the observer.
- Participatory Anthropic Principle The universe, as a condition of its existence, must be observed. As a "self-excited circuit", the universe requires one or more observers to bring its laws into existence.
- Von Neumann-Wigner Interpretation Consciousness causes collapse. Cited as the view Holos bets against: a consciousness-linked deviation from quantum mechanics would falsify Holos (the standing bet).

Consciousness

See: Overview › Consciousness

- 3 • Hard problem of consciousness Chalmers: why does physical activity produce felt experience at all? Holos does not answer this, but reframes it: integration is the condition under which a physical system has an inside view.
- Binding problem How distributed neural activity gives rise to unified experience; Holos frames integration as the boundary where independent parts become a single perspective.
- Neural correlates of consciousness Search for what in the brain matches experience; anesthesia switching it off, and recovery switching it back on, fit integration as the condition for being an observer.
- Global Neuronal Workspace Theory (GNWT) The theory that conscious access happens when a signal lights up and spreads across the brain; Holos treats this as a model of what gets reported, not the deeper threshold (integration) for being an observer at all.
- Integrated Information Theory Consciousness as capacity to integrate information (Φ); Holos uses integration as the threshold for observation, not a full theory of qualia.
- Qualia The subjective character of experience; Holos does not reduce qualia to Φ but treats integration as the condition for "witnessing reality from the inside."
- Panpsychism Consciousness as fundamental in matter; Holos rejects universal panpsychism in favor of a threshold ($\Phi \geq \Phi_c$) so that not everything is an observer.
- Cultured Neural Network Learning Systems Recent laboratory experiments have demonstrated that networks of cultured neurons grown on silicon substrates can be interfaced with digital environments and trained through closed-loop feedback to perform simple tasks, including interacting with video game dynamics. These systems show that biological neural tissue can form adaptive feedback loops and integrated processing structures outside a full organism. While they do not demonstrate consciousness, they provide an experimental platform for studying minimal neural integration and learning dynamics.

Our Universe

[See: Overview › Our Universe](#)

- 4 • [The Big Bang](#) The present universe emerged from an ultra-dense and high-temperature initial state.
- [Accelerating Expansion of the Universe](#) The expansion of the universe is accelerating with time.
- [Spacetime](#) A mathematical model that fuses the three dimensions of space and the one dimension of time.
- [General Relativity](#) Describes gravity as the warping of spacetime by mass and energy.

Spacetime

[See: Overview › Spacetime](#)

- 5 • [Eternalism](#) Time as an unchanging four-dimensional block where all moments exist simultaneously.
- [Block Universe Model](#) The view that past, present, and future exist together as one four-dimensional block. All events are fixed in spacetime; nothing, consciousness included, moves through it.
- [Relativity of Simultaneity](#) Whether two spatially separated events occur at the same time depends on the observer.
- [The Absorber Theory](#) Radiation is a result of both forward-in-time and backward-in-time electromagnetic waves.
- [Spacetime Interval](#) The invariant measure of separation between two events in spacetime. For light the interval is zero, though emission and absorption remain two distinct events.
- [Null Interval](#) A spacetime interval of zero, which occurs along light rays. A zero interval does not make two events one: emission and absorption stay distinct, and no observer can ride the light.
- [Light Cone](#) The boundary of all possible paths that light can take from a given event, defining the causal structure of spacetime.
- [Null Geodesic](#) The path light follows through spacetime. Its interval is zero, but it still connects two distinct events, and nothing can ride along it.
- [Retrocausality](#) The idea that future events can influence past ones. Holos rejects it: the quantum eraser needs no backward influence, only the sorting of records made later.
- [Quantum Eraser Experiment](#) The screen pattern never changes; interference appears only when recorded hits are sorted using later measurements. Ordinary quantum mechanics predicts every result, with nothing traveling backward in time.

Higher Dimensions

[See: Overview › Higher Dimensions](#)

- 6 • [Flatland](#) Satirical novella about a fictional two-dimensional world that explores the concept of inter-dimensional observation.
- [String Theory](#) A proposal that fundamental particles are tiny vibrating strings, requiring extra spatial dimensions. Unconfirmed; Holos takes no position on it.
- [Quantum Gravity](#) The unfinished effort to reconcile gravity with quantum theory; some approaches use extra dimensions, none yet confirmed.
- [Brane Cosmology](#) A proposal that our universe is a slice of a larger, higher-dimensional space. Unconfirmed.
- [Kaluza-Klein Theory](#) A 1920s theory extending general relativity to a fifth dimension, in which electromagnetism appears alongside gravity from one geometry. No extra dimension has been observed.
- [Projective Geometry](#) A branch of geometry studying what stays the same when the point of view changes; parallel lines meet at infinity.

Infinity

[See: Overview › Infinity](#)

- 7 • [Ultraviolet catastrophe](#) Classical physics predicted infinite radiation from hot objects. The infinity signaled a broken description, and the fix, energy in discrete packets, became the foundation of quantum theory.
- [Riemann Sphere](#) An example of how viewing from a higher dimension turns an infinite structure into something finite and observable.
- [Fractals](#) Mathematical sets that can represent infinite complexity within finite boundaries.
- [AdS/CFT Correspondence](#) Higher-dimensional information is encoded into a finite, observable form within lower dimensions.
- [Infinite Sets](#) Provide a foundation for understanding how infinities can be compared, ordered, and wrapped.
- [Cellular Automata](#) Complex, infinite patterns and behaviors can emerge from simple initial conditions and rules.
- [Point at Infinity](#) In projective geometry, the point where parallel lines converge, representing the boundary where infinite space folds into a finite structure.

Black Holes

[See: Overview › Black Holes](#)

- 8 • Black Hole Thermodynamics The study of the physical properties of black holes.
- Event Horizon The boundary around a black hole beyond which nothing, not even light, can escape.
- Cosmic Censorship Hypothesis Singularities are always hidden within event horizons.
- Loop Quantum Gravity Space and time come in tiny discrete chunks rather than being smooth, folding infinite structure into finite loops.
- Holographic Principle All information contained in a given volume of space can be represented as encoded on a lower-dimensional boundary.

Aliens

See: Overview › Aliens

- 9 • Fermi Paradox The discrepancy between the lack of evidence for extraterrestrial life and the high likelihood of its existence. Holos reframes this silence through the Integration Hypothesis: advancement favors compact, efficient integration over expansion and broadcast, so maturity coincides with electromagnetic quiet.
- Early broadcasting phase The early biological and broadcasting phase of a civilization. Any hurdle (abiogenesis, nuclear war, coordination failure) that stops a civilization before deep integration is an early filter relative to true maturity.
- Light-speed latency A high-integration intelligence cannot function with years of light-speed lag between star systems. Independent interstellar colonies either fragment into less-capable outposts or the civilization turns inward, deepening local integration instead of expanding.
- Dark Nodes The hypothesized mature state: compact, non-luminous systems built from ordinary matter, a trace population detectable, if at all, by gravity and waste heat rather than light (the Teeming Dark). Not cosmological dark matter, which predates any possible life.
- Waste-heat SETI (the $\hat{G}$ survey) Wright et al. (2014): infrared searches for civilizations with large energy supplies, built on the principle that waste heat is the one emission technology cannot eliminate. This is the search channel the Teeming Dark aligns with: silent, but warm. A channel, not a fingerprint: warm dark masses are also what failed stars and cooled remnants look like.
- Ehrenfest argument Paul Ehrenfest (1917) showed that in dimensions greater than three, atomic orbitals and inverse-square planetary systems would destabilize. Matter would spiral into nuclei/stars or fly apart. Holos agrees, and goes further: higher dimensions are descriptions, not places. Nothing migrates into them (Axiom 4).
- Ephemerization R. Buckminster Fuller (1938): the process of doing ‘more and more with less and less’ until intelligence can ‘do everything with nothing’. Advanced civilizations migrate inwardly toward higher densities of information rather than expanding outwardly across physical space.

- The Transcension Hypothesis John Smart (2011): advanced civilizations migrate to inner space for efficiency. Holos shares the inward-turn conclusion but not the mechanism: no transmutation or dimensional exit is proposed. Mature systems remain ordinary matter that has stopped shining.
- Cosmological natural selection Lee Smolin (1992): universes evolve to create more black holes; black hole collapse may give rise to daughter universes with slightly different constants. Cited as related work in spirit; Holos takes no position on it and proposes no mechanism linking intelligence to black holes.
- Substrate independence The view that a mind could run on different kinds of physical material, not just brains. Holos agrees that pattern matters more than material, without claiming minds can run on anything beyond ordinary matter.
- Dark matter The unexplained “missing mass” holding galaxies together. Holos takes no position on its particle nature and does not identify it with life: its fingerprints in the CMB predate stars, chemistry, and any possible builder. Mature civilizations belong instead to the non-luminous side of ordinary matter.
- Dyson sphere A hypothetical megastructure that would encompass a star to capture its energy. Their absence is consistent with the Integration Hypothesis: mature civilizations concentrate rather than sprawl. But thermodynamics still applies: waste heat, not visible structure, is the unavoidable search target.
- Brane cosmology The idea that our 3D universe may be a thin brane in a larger, higher-dimensional space. Unconfirmed; Holos takes no position, and proposes no migration into extra dimensions.

The Teeming Dark

See: [Overview › The Teeming Dark](#)

- 10 • Massive compact halo object (MACHO) Microlensing surveys watched millions of stars for dark compact masses and found too few to make up a large hidden population. Dark Nodes can only be a trace population.
- Missing baryon problem Surveys have now located nearly all the ordinary matter the early universe records, leaving little room for hidden built structures.

The Omega Point

See: [Overview › The Omega Point](#)

- 11 • Panentheism The belief that the divine intersects every part of the universe and also extends beyond space and time.
- Brahman The pervasive, infinite, eternal truth, consciousness and bliss which does not change, yet is the cause of all changes.

- Omega Point A future event in which the entirety of the universe spirals toward a final point of unification.
- Advaita Vedanta The nondual school of Indian philosophy holding that there is one experiencer, and that each individual consciousness is that one seen through a local form; a named ancestor of the Holos monist reading.
- Baruch Spinoza Philosopher of substance monism: one substance, of which all finite things are modes or expressions.
- George Berkeley Idealist philosopher who grounded the persistence of the unobserved world in a perceiver that never looks away.

Why Are We Here?

See: Overview › Why Are We Here?

- 12 • Unitarity The principle that probabilities must sum to one, ensuring the conservation of information in quantum mechanics. Whether this holds inside black holes is the open information paradox.
- Many-Worlds Interpretation Every possible outcome of a quantum measurement occurs in a separate, branching universe.
- Speed of Light The universe's fixed speed limit. Along a light ray the spacetime interval is zero, though emission and absorption remain distinct events.
- Indra's Net An ancient Buddhist and Hindu metaphor describing an infinite web where every node is a jewel that reflects all other jewels, representing the interconnected, recursive nature of reality where each part contains and reflects the whole.

Holos

See: Overview › Holos

- 13 • Structural Realism The view that science describes the relationships between things, not what they are made of in themselves.
- Holos The interconnected, unified, recursive structure of reality as formed through the reciprocal actions of creation and observation, symbolized by $\otimes$.
- Recursive Operator Holos's iteration: each registered history becomes the context for further possibilities. A conceptual tool for recursive closure, not a process unfolding in time.

Logic

Core

See: [Logic > Core](#)

- 14 • Bekenstein Bound An upper limit on the entropy or information that can be contained within a given limited region of space which has a finite amount of energy. It suggests that information is fundamentally tied to the geometry of the universe.
- Bekenstein, J. (2003) Information in the holographic universe. Scientific American.

Definition

See: [Logic > Definition](#)

- 15 • Integrated Information Theory IIT identifies consciousness with integrated information (Φ). Holos borrows Φ as a measure of integration only; the threshold Φ_c is its own commitment, not IIT's.

Comparison

See: [Logic > Comparison](#)

- 16 • Many-worlds interpretation Everett (1957): every possible outcome of a quantum event really happens, in its own branch. Holos agrees all branches exist, but adds that only some are registered as anyone's actual experience.
- Relational quantum mechanics Rovelli (1996): quantum properties are relative to observers; Holos aligns on relational facts and extends with a threshold ($\Phi \geq \Phi_c$) for what counts as an observer.
- QBism Quantum Bayesianism: quantum probabilities are agent-centered beliefs; Holos is ontological (what is lived) rather than epistemic (what agents believe).
- Copenhagen interpretation Classical interpretation with wavefunction collapse; Holos drops collapse entirely: evolution stays unitary, branches remain, and each is registered from within.
- Objective collapse theories Theories in which collapse is a physical process; Holos rejects them. A consciousness-linked collapse would falsify Holos outright (the standing bet).

Primitives

See: [Logic > Primitives](#)

- 17 • Information The differentiation between possible states of a system (the difference that makes a difference).

- Phase Space The space of all possible states of a system. Creation is the space of lawful states and trajectories; Observation registers trajectories from within and selects none.
- Invariant (physics) Reality is stable relationships, not fixed properties things carry on their own. ® describes what stays constant in that structure, not how it changes over time.

Axioms

See: Logic › Axioms

- 18 • Ontology The study of what exists. Holos separates structure, which exists whether or not it is lived, from presence, which requires observers.
- Epistemology The study of knowledge and belief. Holos distinguishes epistemic inference (what we know) from ontological presence (what is lived).

Foundations

See: Logic › Foundations

- 19 • Probability Theory ® is not probability weighting: the Born weights are structural facts within C, while ® concerns which structures are lived.
- Wave Function Collapse ® is not a physical collapse happening over time. No outcome is picked; each branch is registered from within.
- Bayesian Inference Bayesian updating describes belief revision (epistemic). ® describes how structure becomes present (ontological).
- Equivalence Relation Lived and unlived partition histories into two classes: a structural classification, not a transition between states.

Ontology

See: Logic › Ontology

- 20 • Aaronson (2014), Why I Am Not An Integrated Information Theorist Shows that very simple, inert structures can score higher on integration measures than a brain. Holos answers with the aboutness requirement: integrated states must model a world beyond the system.
- Harnad (1990), The symbol grounding problem Physica D: symbols connected only to other symbols are not about anything until some of them ground out in perception. Holos builds this into aboutness: a model must be grounded in senses of the system's own.
- Friedman et al. (2010), Evidence for neural inertia PLoS ONE: in animals, consciousness is lost and regained at different anesthetic levels. A lag of that kind is a hallmark of sharp switches, the signature Holos's threshold predicts.

- Ontology The philosophical study of being and existence. Φ quantifies how much a system integrates information to register ontologically distinct states.
- Causality The causal power to register a distinct ontological state. Φ acts as the threshold for when a system becomes an observer rather than passive data.
- Quantum Decoherence The process by which quantum systems interact with their environment. Decoherence yields classical-looking branches; Φ marks where within them experience occurs.

Relationship to Physics

See: Logic › Relationship to Physics

- 21
- Unitarity (physics) Quantum mechanics requires unitarity. Holos preserves it fully: nothing collapses, nothing is selected, and unobserved branches remain in Creation as unlit structure.
 - Hilbert Space The mathematical space of all possible quantum states. Holos deletes no branches from it; the Born weights are structural facts about it.
 - Schrödinger Equation Φ does not replace or modify the Schrödinger equation. It marks where experience occurs and leaves the quantum math untouched.
 - Quantum Mechanics Φ preserves the probabilistic nature of quantum mechanics while adding a constraint on when observation registers reality.
 - Born rule Max Born (1926): quantum probabilities are squared amplitudes, the most precisely confirmed rule in physics. In Holos the weights are structural facts within C, fixing the statistics each observer records rather than measuring how much experience a branch carries.
 - Gleason's theorem Andrew Gleason (1957): any consistent assignment of probabilities to quantum outcomes must take the Born-rule form: exactly one weighting is possible. Its assumptions remain debated; Holos adds no new mathematics.
 - Sebens and Carroll (2018), Self-locating uncertainty and the origin of probability in Everettian quantum mechanics British Journal for the Philosophy of Science: after branching and before looking, an observer is uncertain which branch they are in, and the Born weights are the rational odds. Holos adopts this reading of the weights and reaches it by elimination: counting fails, weight survives.
 - Ontology Histories that contain observers are lived; the rest remain unlit structure. The underlying quantum math is unaltered.

Notation

See: Logic › Notation

- 22 • Information Theory Sending information assumes a causal signal passes between places; $\otimes$ sends nothing. It concerns which histories are lived, not which signals travel.
- Measurement in Quantum Mechanics Measurement models the physical interaction between systems; Observation in Holos is registration from within. It selects nothing and alters no interaction.
- Hilbert Space In modern physics, the "state" of any complex system is defined as a vector in a high-dimensional space. Our perception of 3D space is a specific observable projection of this deeper geometric reality.

Extrapolation

See: Logic › Extrapolation

- 23 • Ephemeralization R. Buckminster Fuller (1938): the process of doing more with less until intelligence can do everything with nothing. Advanced civilizations migrate inwardly toward higher densities of information.
- Ehrenfest argument Paul Ehrenfest (1917) showed that in dimensions greater than three, atomic orbitals and inverse-square planetary systems would destabilize. Holos agrees, and goes further: higher dimensions are descriptions, not places. Nothing migrates into them (Axiom 4).

Predictions

Introduction

See: Predictions › Introduction

- 24 • Dynamics (physics) Holos does not propose new dynamical laws; it offers ontological predictions about how reality manifests ($R = C \otimes O$).
- Ontology Predictions about how structure becomes present as experience. Observers register the block universe from within; they do not hold it together.
- Block universe The structural layer of Holos: tenseless and observer-independent. Observers register it from within; its consistency does not depend on them.
- Anthropic principle Holos reframes anthropic selection as ontological filtering: observer-free universes may exist as structure but are never lived.
- Cosmic microwave background (CMB) polarization CMB-S4, LiteBIRD: searching the polarization of the earliest light for primordial gravitational waves, a test of inflation. Holos makes no prediction here.

- Past hypothesis The universe began in a highly ordered, low-entropy state. In Holos, branches where nothing could live remain unlit: real as structure, never lived (no Φ).
- Inflation (cosmology) A proposed early phase of rapid expansion that would explain the universe's flatness and smoothness. Holos takes no position on it.
- Multiverse Branches where nothing could live are real as structure, but in Holos they are never lived (no Φ).

Commitments

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- Integrated Information Theory (IIT) Holos borrows Φ as a measure of integration, not IIT's identity claim. Crossing Φ_c is where experience occurs; PCI is a practical proxy.
 - Panpsychism Holos distinguishes from universal panpsychism (everything conscious) and illusionism (consciousness is illusion).
 - Illusionism (philosophy) The view that consciousness is an illusion. Holos rejects it: experience is the one fact the framework starts from.
 - Qualia The felt character of experience. Holos locates qualia in systems that meet the observer requirements; below Φ_c there is processing without experience.
 - Perturbational Complexity Index (PCI) IIT-inspired metric with an empirically calibrated cutoff between conscious and unconscious states. Holos treats it as a proxy for integration, not a detector of presence.
 - Phase transition Holos treats the onset of experience as a switch at Φ_c , not a dial. A sharp jump alone would not confirm this, since ordinary models predict tipping points too.

Expectations

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- Extended Wigner's Friend experiments Two observers can hold different registered facts about the same event without breaking unitarity. In Holos each fact is indexed to its branch and observer.
 - Unitarity (physics) Conservation of all possibilities; Holos predicts agreement among communicating observers without objective collapse.
 - Relational quantum mechanics Holos borrows RQM's point that facts are indexed to observing systems, but sides with branching, which keeps the universal state RQM rejects.
 - Objective collapse theories Holos rejects objective collapse: evolution is unitary, and apparent collapse is registration within a branch.

Testability and Its Limits

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- 27 • Wigner's friend Registered facts are observer-indexed; no objective collapse. Extended Wigner's-friend experiments constrain the family of views Holos belongs to (Check B).
- Bong et al. (2020), A strong no-go theorem on the Wigner's friend paradox Nature Physics: the Local Friendliness theorem and its photonic test. Absoluteness of observed events, locality, and freedom of choice cannot all hold; Holos gives up the first.
 - Siclari et al. (2017), The neural correlates of dreaming Nature Neuroscience: dream reports occur after awakenings from both REM and NREM sleep, tracked by local activity in posterior cortex. The live challenge for Test A.
 - Phase transition If the threshold is a genuine critical point, it should leave measurable signatures near the boundary; see A path to the threshold.
 - TMS-EEG PCI is computed from TMS-EEG responses; it is the integration proxy Test A relies on.
 - Perturbational Complexity Index (PCI) Validated across sleep, anesthesia, and disorders of consciousness; Test A uses it to separate integration from responsiveness.
 - Propofol / BIS index Anesthesia depth: one of the states Test A compares. A drop in integration alone confirms nothing specific to Holos.
 - Recurrent neural network Recurrent architectures; relevant to whether artificial systems can meet the recursion and integration requirements for observation.
 - Neuromorphic engineering Artificial systems with feedback; integration as emergent boundary rather than performance metric.
 - Causal density Proxy for Φ when direct computation infeasible; perturbation-based complexity.
 - Collective intelligence Social networks / agent networks; integration thresholds (nonlinear increase) as scale increases.
 - Mutual information Integration proxy: mutual information across subgroups, causal density, network-wide coherence.
 - Network theory Small-world, scale-free; integration as potentially ontological, not merely functional.
 - Relational quantum mechanics Holos shares RQM's observer-indexed facts but not its rejection of a universal state; a positive Check B result supports the family, not Holos alone.

Speculation

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- 28 • Phase transition A speculative reading: civilizational integration may advance in jumps rather than smoothly, as light-speed delay and waste heat reshape what can be coordinated.
- Ephemerization Doing more with less: advancement as inward growth toward higher informational density rather than outward expansion.
 - Fermi paradox Holos resolution: the Integration Hypothesis and Visibility Collapse. Mature civilizations are silent in light; the unavoidable observables are gravity and waste heat.
 - Hanson et al. (2021), If loud aliens explain human earliness, quiet aliens are also rare The Astrophysical Journal: the grabby aliens model. Visible, expanding civilizations exist but have not reached us, and we are early. Named on the site as the main rival to the Integration Hypothesis.
 - Griffith et al. (2015), The G infrared search, III The Astrophysical Journal Supplement: of about 100,000 galaxies surveyed with WISE, none hosts a civilization reprocessing more than 85% of its starlight into waste heat.
 - Zoo hypothesis The idea that mature civilizations deliberately leave young ones alone. For Holos, non-contact needs no agreement: leaving a young civilization alone costs nothing, while contact takes effort.
 - Weakly interacting massive particles (WIMPs) A leading dark-matter particle candidate. Holos takes no position on the particle nature of cosmological dark matter, which predates life; Dark Nodes are non-luminous ordinary matter.
 - Euclid Mission March 2025 Q1 data: 26M galaxies, precision mass mapping. Compact mass peaks with weak visible counterparts become interesting only after conventional explanations fail, and only alongside an infrared excess.
 - James Webb Space Telescope (JWST) Deep-field mass structure under active study. For Holos, a candidate Dark Node requires gravity plus faint warmth, not gravity alone.
 - Baryon Ordinary matter. Dark Nodes remain baryonic: built matter that stops shining, not matter that changes kind. No transmutation is proposed.
 - Navarro-Frenk-White profile Halo-profile deviations have viable conventional explanations (baryonic feedback, mergers, measurement limits). Holos claims no dark-matter anomaly.
 - Lambda-CDM model The standard cosmological model. Holos does not modify it: cosmological dark matter is primordial and predates any possible life.
 - Dark Energy Survey (DES) Jan 2026 final analysis: an open clustering tension. Holos offers no interpretation of it.
 - JWST COSMOS-Web Granular mass structure under study. A Dark Node candidate would need compact mass plus infrared warmth; mass alone is not evidence.

Technology

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- Computronium Hypothetical material optimized for computation; the Computronium Kernel is a maximally compact core for coherent, long-horizon world-modeling.
 - Megastructure Large-scale artificial structures; Holos mesostructures (Kernel, Chrono Vault) are compact and coherence-optimized rather than maximally expansive.
 - Gravitational lens Bending of light by mass; gravitational-lens observatories use natural lenses for extreme resolution without large radiative infrastructure.
 - Time capsule The Chrono Vault extends this idea to civilizational identity: preserving value systems, decision histories, and continuity across deep time.
 - Interstellar communication At cosmic scales, communication converges on phase-coherent optical payloads and compressed, self-describing models rather than real-time dialogue.
 - Space probe Sentinel Probes are compact, autonomous, long-duration instruments that resolve observational ambiguities and operate without real-time control.